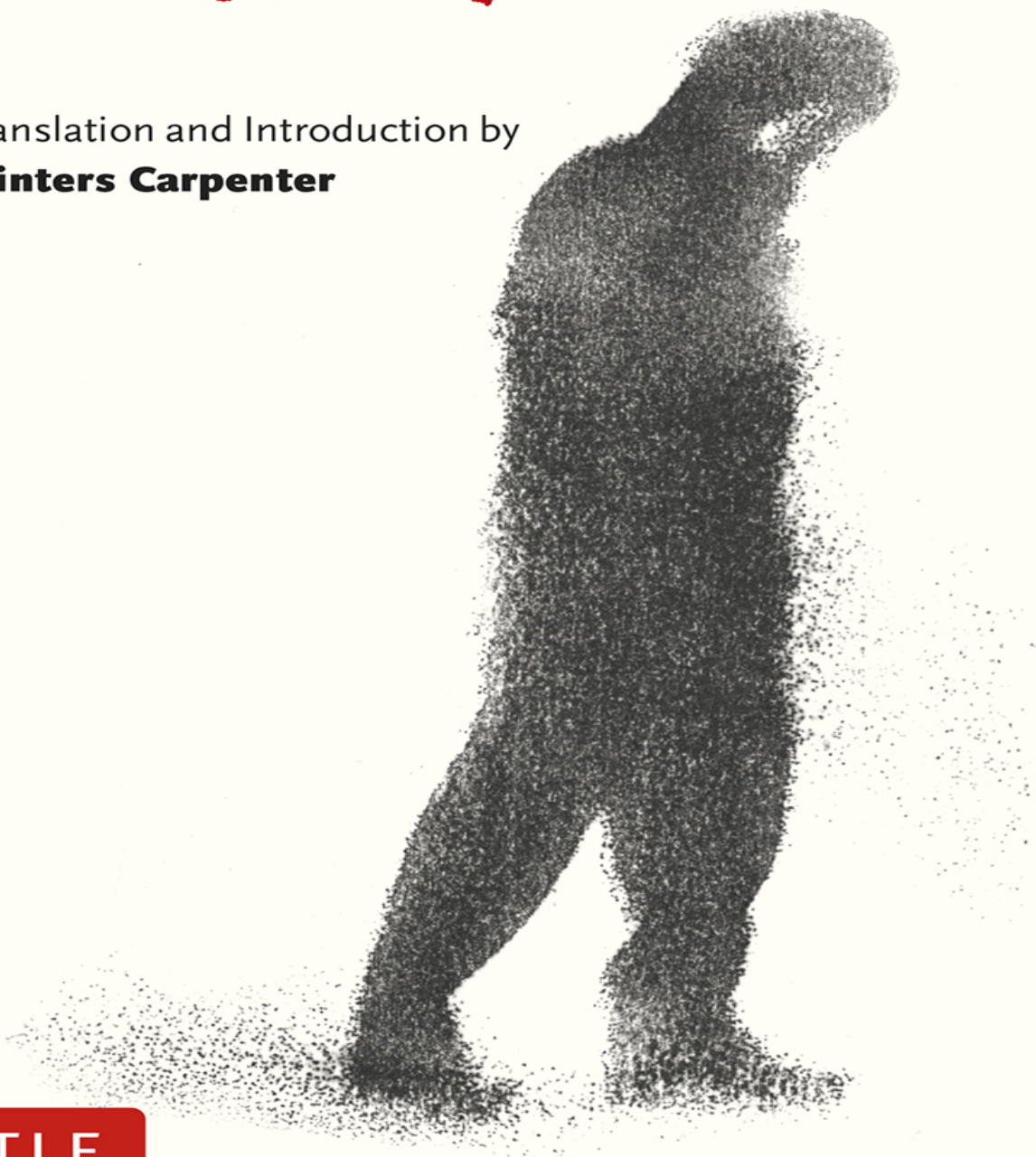
OSAMU DAZAI

NO LONGER HUMAN

A New Translation and Introduction by
Juliet Winters Carpenter



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Translator’s Introduction

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Osamu Dazai is one of Japan's most celebrated and beloved modern authors. He was born in 1909, at the end of the time of frantic modernization known as the Meiji era, and he died in 1948 as, in the wake of defeat in World War II, the country was once again in the throes of transition. He wrote in a variety of genres (short story, memoir, sardonic fairytale retellings, travelogue) but was a particular master of the *shishosetsu* or "I-novel," an autobiographical, confessional form of fiction that has played a key role in modern Japanese literature. The dark, wry tone of Dazai's later novels resonated with readers reeling from the devastation of World War II and the accompanying loss of traditional values and moorings. He gave that generation a literary voice, expressing feelings of despair, isolation and confusion with self-deprecating humor and raw honesty. Through first-person narrators that are essentially stand-ins for himself he explored the perverse feelings, insecurities, weaknesses and failings that are precisely what the rest of us prefer to keep concealed even from ourselves. Yukio Mishima wrote with some pique that Dazai "worked deliberately to expose what I most wanted to hide."[1] This artful tearing away of the social mask surely underpins Dazai's extraordinary popularity, as to this day reader after reader picks up one of his works only to experience the shock of recognition as they find aspects of their inmost self

mirrored in its pages, written in a sensitive style that seems aimed directly at them.

Like Yozo Oba, the protagonist of *No Longer Human*, Dazai was born into a large, wealthy family in the remote Tohoku region of northern Japan. His real name was Shuji Tsushima, and he was the tenth of eleven children. A gifted student, he first took up writing in high school, moved by the suicide of the great short-story writer Ryunosuke Akutagawa, whom he idolized. Dazai is remembered as much for his life of dissipation as for his oeuvre. Over a span of twenty years, he attempted suicide multiple times, three times with a lover. One time, the young woman perished while he survived; another time, both he and she survived. He was expelled from Tokyo Imperial University. He ran off with a geisha. He was arrested for illegal involvement in the activities of the banned Communist party. He was disowned and reconciled with his family more than once. He developed tuberculosis and was addicted to morphine and alcohol. Toward the end of his life, by then a lionized celebrity, he devoted himself to his writing with renewed energy and determination. Finally, in June 1948, he jumped into a rain-swollen stream with his then-mistress, and on this occasion they both succeeded in dying. Their bodies were discovered on what would have been his thirty-ninth birthday.

No Longer Human is Dazai's last complete novel, finished shortly before he died. It is the number two best-selling novel by Japanese publishing house Shinchosa (second only to Soseki's *Kokoro*).[2] Yozo Oba, who narrates the story through the device of a series of notebooks, recounts escapades in what he calls his "life of much shame," closely paralleling the events of Dazai's colorful life. The title (*Ningen shikkaku* in Japanese, literally "disqualified as a human being") refers to Yozo's deep sense of alienation, his inability to fathom what makes his fellow human beings tick. He feels superior to others, yet at the same time he deeply fears them. To mask his fear and also to gain love and acceptance, he adopts the persona of a clown, always trying to make others laugh with his shenanigans. The pervasive gloom in the novel is lightened by Yozo's ironic self-awareness as

well as by Dazai's genius for storytelling and his protean, fluid style.

Recently I was surprised to find certain similarities between Yozo and a beloved character in a classic Hollywood film: the Cowardly Lion in *The Wizard of Oz*. E.Y. "Yip" Harburg, the film's lyricist, made this comment:

> [T]he role [of the Cowardly Lion] was one of the things *The Wizard of Oz* stands for; the search for some basic human necessity . . . Call it anxiety, call it neurosis. We're in a world we don't understand. When the Cowardly Lion admits that he lacks courage, everybody's heart is out to him. He must be somebody who embodies all this pathos, sweetness, and yet puts on the comic bravura.[3]

As a small boy, Yozo lacked the courage to tell his father he wanted a book rather than a lion mask, let alone that he was being molested by the servants. Beset with lifelong fear and anxiety, tormented by bewilderment at a world that defied understanding, he too coped by facing life with "comic bravura." He too had an essential sweetness summed up in the bar madam's surprising last words: "The Yo-chan we knew was sweet and thoughtful. If he just hadn't been a drinker . . . but no, even then, he was a dear boy. An angel."

The reader will note that Yozo is drawn almost exclusively to Western culture and philosophy. While he is a professional manga artist and also sells erotic *shunga*-style works, he refers familiarly to Modigliani, van Gogh and other artists; quotes an obscure French poet and the *Rubaiyat* of Omar Khayyam; and scatters brief prayers and references to Christianity throughout his notebooks. The only musical instrument played in the novel is a piano, the only film star is an American comedian named Harold Lloyd. Yozo imagines his lost paintings and the career he might have had as an "unfinished glass of absinthe," drawing on the image of that liqueur as a symbol of mad genius extolled by nineteenth-century European poets and painters. Post-Meiji Japanese intellectuals were immersed in and identified with the literary and artistic heritage of the West. Yozo's family does not

seem to be overtly Christian, but Yozo clearly has read at least the New Testament, is aware of the doctrine of original sin, and has scorn for “fake Christians” and their “nice” smiles. Acquaintance with Christianity was to some extent fashionable, a bit like the drinking of milk in “milk halls” that became wildly popular in the Taisho era (1912–26).

In an interesting twist on the process of cultural sharing, Dazai has recently soared to new heights of worldwide fame through a character named for him in the ongoing manga and anime series *Bungo Stray Dogs*, which first came out in 2014. Most, if not all, characters in the series are named after famous Japanese authors and poets and reflect their lives and personalities; “Osamu Dazai,” for example, tries repeatedly to commit suicide but, somewhat comically, can never seem to pull it off. BSD readers have been turning to Dazai and other modern Japanese authors whose works they might otherwise never have encountered, and they are sharing their discoveries on social media, especially TikTok. One such fan made this comment, with which many readers past and present would agree: “I really love [*No Longer Human*]. It is probably one of the first pieces of media that I’ve ever felt represented in.”[4] One can only welcome and applaud this trend.

Of course, *No Longer Human* was first introduced to anglophone readers through the masterful translation by Donald Keene published in 1958. Rereading that translation recently for the first time in more than half a century, I was filled with admiration for its smoothness, its sure command of the varied resources of the English language and its heart. Still, languages do change over time, and new, modern translations can bring important works of literature to a younger generation of readers. Since *No Longer Human* was the first Japanese novel I ever read in the original for pleasure, it has been a special honor for me to revisit this timeless classic.

Juliet Winters Carpenter
July 2023

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2. " ." Yomiuri Shimbun (in Japanese). 6 June 2018. https://www.yomiuri.co.jp/fukayomi/20180608-OYT8T50003/
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Prologue

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はしがき

I have seen three snapshots of him.

The first was taken in what might be called his tender years, around the age of ten. He was standing at the edge of a garden pond, surrounded by girls (his sisters and cousins, I'd imagine), his head tilted slightly to the left, wearing a kimono, broad-striped *hakama* trousers and an ugly smile. Ugly? Granted, his smile contained just enough of what passes for "cuteness" that if dullards (by which I mean those blind to beauty and ugliness) chirped, "What a cute little boy!" even that generic compliment wouldn't sound completely empty; yet anyone who had acquired a slightly discriminating eye might well take one look, mutter "Horrible child!" and fling the photo aside in disgust, the way you would a caterpillar.

The more I looked at that smile, the more it struck me as weird and unpleasant. To begin with, it *wasn't* a smile, not at all. You could tell because he was standing with his fists clenched. Humans aren't designed to smile and clench their fists at the same time. He was a monkey, smiling a

monkey smile. His face had ugly wrinkles. The phrase “wizened little boy” comes to mind; that’s how odd, how repulsive and sickening the look on his face was. Never in my life had I seen a child with an expression so baffling.

In the second snapshot he looked quite different, astonishingly so. He was dressed as a student, though whether in high school or college I couldn’t say. In any case, he was extraordinarily handsome. And yet, once again, he did not give the impression of a live human being. He had on a school uniform with a white handkerchief poking out of the breast pocket, and he was sitting in a rattan chair with his legs crossed, smiling. This time the smile displayed some cleverness. It wasn’t a wrinkly monkey grimace, but it was still somehow off, not quite human. There was no trace of what you might call the heaviness of blood, the sting of life. Completely lacking in substance, his expression was as light as feathery down. He was a blank sheet of paper, smiling. In short, he was altogether fake. “Affected” doesn’t come close, and neither does “insincere” or “foppish” or of course “stylish.” The more I studied the image of that handsome student, the more I felt there was something vaguely uncanny about it, as if he belonged in a ghost story. Never in my life had I seen a handsome young man whose looks were so baffling.

The third photo was the most disturbing of all. It was impossible to say how old he was. His hair had gone rather gray. He was sitting in a corner of a badly rundown room (the photo showed plain as day that the walls were crumbling in three places), holding his hands over a small charcoal brazier, but this time he wasn’t smiling. His face was expressionless. It was as if while sitting there in the act of warming his hands, he had died a natural death. The photo had an utterly repugnant and sinister aura. But that’s not all that made it disturbing. The photo was in medium close-up, so I was able to study how his face was put together. The forehead was ordinary, as were the lines in the forehead, the eyebrows, and the eyes, likewise the nose, mouth and chin. His face not only lacked expression—it made no impression whatever. There was nothing distinctive about it. All I had to do was close my eyes after looking at his face, and instantly it faded from

memory. The walls and the little charcoal brazier I could remember, but the face of the owner of the room simply vanished, irretrievably gone. It wasn't a face you could paint a likeness of or draw in a manga. I opened my eyes. No rush of pleasure, no *Oh, that's right! Now I remember!* To put it in stark terms, even after opening my eyes and looking at the photograph again, I still couldn't remember his face. I only felt unpleasant and irritated and wanted to look away.

The shadow of death itself surely has more expression, makes more of an impression, than did that face. If you stuck a nag's head on a human body, would the result be any less monstrous? Somehow, the face in that photo had a chilling, horrifying effect on me. I repeat—never in my life had I seen a man's face that was so utterly baffling.

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Notebook One

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第一の手記

I have lived a life of much shame.

I have no idea what it must be like to live as a human being. Born in the Tohoku countryside, I never saw a train until I was fairly big. I scampered up and down the station overpass without realizing it was there to let people cross over the train tracks. All I could think was that the station was designed like a foreign playground, complicated in a fun way, modern and stylish. I went on thinking that for quite some time. Going up and down the overpass seemed to me a refined sort of game, the niftiest of all the services the railway provided, and later on when I found it was actually a practical set of stairways to enable passengers to cross over the tracks, all my pleasure evaporated.

As a child, I first saw a subway train in a picture book, and again I was

convinced that such a thing had been devised not out of practical necessity but because compared to riding aboveground, riding underground would be so much more unusual and entertaining.

I was sickly as a child and often took to my bed, where I thought the sheets, pillowcases and quilt covers were all unnecessary decorations. When in my late teens I realized their utilitarian value, human thriftiness left me feeling depressed and sad.

I never knew what hunger was, either. By this I obviously don't mean simply that I grew up in a home with ample provision for the necessities of life. I mean that I had no notion of the sensation of hunger. Strange as this may sound, even if I was hungry, I was never actually aware of it. When I came home from school, people would fuss over me: "You must be starving. I remember how that feels! The hunger pains you suffer when you come home from school are the worst. How about some candied beans? There's pound cake and buns, too." Always accommodating, I would mutter, "Yeah, I'm starving," and throw a handful of candied beans in my mouth. But what it felt like to be hungry, I had no idea.

I'm a hearty eater, all right, but I have no recollection of ever eating out of hunger. I am drawn to foods that are fancy or out of the ordinary. When I'm a guest somewhere, generally I eat what I'm offered, even if it takes an effort to get it down. The most difficult ordeal for me in childhood was definitely mealtime at home.

I grew up in a big country family—there were a good ten of us—and at meals we would all sit on the tatami in two facing rows, each with our own tray-table. As the youngest, I of course occupied the very last place. The room where we ate was dimly lit, and the sight of ten or more people sitting and eating in gloomy silence was chilling. Also, because ours was an old-fashioned country household, the foods on the menu were set, with no possibility of anything the least fancy or out of the ordinary. Mealtime came to hold terrors for me. Sitting in the last seat in that shadowy room, shivering from the cold as bit by bit I lifted morsels of food to my mouth and swallowed them, I wondered why people ate three times a day, anyway.

Everyone looked so solemn, it occurred to me that meals might be a kind of ritual carried out three times daily at specified times, a ritual requiring everyone to gather in a dimly lit room, take their places in neat rows, and, whether they felt like it or not, sit with faces downturned and chew in silence as they prayed to the household gods.

Eat or die: this expression sounded to my ears like an unpleasant bit of intimidation, no more. But that superstition (even now, I can't help thinking of it as such) brought me constant anxiety and fear. People work for a living because they have to feed themselves, or else they'll die: nothing was so impenetrable and obscure to me, so starkly threatening, as those words.

To this day I have no idea why humans do the things they do. As a child, I had an uneasy sense that my concept of happiness was utterly different from the one everyone else shared, an uneasiness that made me toss on my futon night after night and moan, nearly out of my mind. Have I ever known happiness? All my life people have been telling me how fortunate I am, but I have always, always felt that I was going through the torments of hell and that those who called me fortunate were infinitely better off.

Sometimes I feel as if I were burdened with ten woes so heavy that if my neighbor had to bear even one, it would be enough to do him in.

In short, I don't get it. I lack the ability to grasp the nature or degree of my neighbor's suffering. For all I know, "practical" suffering—the sort that can be ended by putting food in one's stomach—might be the most hellish of all, ghastly enough to blow my ten woes right out of the water. I really can't say. But then how do sufferers manage to carry on without killing themselves or going mad, stay interested in politics, resolutely continue the struggle to live and never give into despair? Can their suffering be genuine? They are complete egotists and see nothing wrong with that, never doubt themselves in the least—is that it? That would make life easy. Maybe all humans are like that, maybe that's how they're supposed to be, I don't know . . . maybe they sleep soundly at night and wake up in the morning refreshed. What dreams do they dream? What do they think about as they walk down the street? Money? Surely not only that. We live to eat, I think I

have heard it said, but never have I heard it said that we live for money. And yet, maybe . . . no, I don't know. The more I think about things, the less I understand and the more I'm overwhelmed by the anxiety and fear that I alone am different from everybody else. I can hardly have a conversation with my neighbor. What should I say, how should I say it? I have no idea.

That's how I came up with the idea of acting the clown.

This was my final way of asking humans for love. Humans terrified me in the extreme, but I couldn't separate myself from them without regret. Acting the clown allowed me to feel a tenuous connection with humanity. On the outside I was always wearing a smile, but inside I was desperate, feeling I was skating on the edge of disaster, working up a nervous sweat as I offered entertainment. From childhood on, I could never imagine how anyone—even members of my own family—might be suffering or what thoughts went through their heads as they lived their lives. People simply scared me silly, and clowning around was my way of dealing with awkwardness and fear. I soon became quite good at it. In short, I turned into a child who never spoke a word of truth. In family photos from around that time, everyone else looks sober and only I am grinning, my face always twisted in some peculiar way. That was another form of the sad, childish clown acts I used to perform.

I never talked back to my family. The slightest scolding hit me like a clap of thunder, drove me nearly out of my mind; far from talking back, I would feel as if the scolding expressed a timeless truth handed down through generations, one I was so incapable of acting on that I suspected myself unfit for human society. Arguing back or defending myself was impossible. When someone rebuked me, I would think *Yes, it's true*, and feel that I had made a grave mistake; I always bore the attack in silence, gripped by a terror great enough to unhinge me.

Probably no one enjoys getting criticized or yelled at, but when I looked into the face of an angry person, I saw a wild beast in its true colors, a beast more terrifying than a lion, alligator or dragon. Normally people hide their true nature, but at unexpected moments—as when a cow lying peacefully in

a pasture suddenly lashes out with its tail to kill a fly on its flank—a sudden burst of anger can expose it, causing me to shudder with fright and my hair to stand on end. I nearly lost all hope for my own existence when I thought that such brutishness might be something else that humans need to survive.

Other people made me shake with fear, and my own words and actions failed to bolster my confidence. I shut away my private anguish in a tiny mental compartment, keeping my gloom and nervousness secret and putting on a determined show of innocent cheer until, little by little, my transformation into a droll eccentric was complete.

All I have to do is make people laugh, any old way; then even if I stay outside of their lives they might not mind; the thing is not to be an eyesore, to be nothing, the wind, the sky: as these thoughts mounted, I acted as a jester around my family in frantic desperation and also around the servants, male and female, who were even more incomprehensible and terrifying to me than my family.

In the summertime I made them all laugh by walking around the house with a red wool sweater on underneath my cotton kimono. Even my eldest brother, who seldom cracks a smile, burst out laughing. “Yo-chan, that’s, uh, not the best look for you.” His tone indicated he thought me adorable. Well, I wasn’t so far gone that I’d actually wear a wool sweater in the middle of summer like some moron who doesn’t know hot from cold, thank you. I had merely slipped a pair of my sister’s leggings on my arms so they showed at the wrist under my kimono sleeves, making it *look* as if I were wearing a sweater.

My father frequently had business in Tokyo, so he had a second home in the city’s Ueno district, where he spent the better part of each month. When he came back, he always brought a ton of presents for everyone in the family, including more distant relatives. It was kind of a hobby of his.

One time, the night before he was leaving for Tokyo, he gathered us children in the living room and asked each one with a big smile, “What do you want me to bring you back next time?” then carefully wrote down the answer in a notebook. It was unusual for him to shower us with so much

attention. When my turn came, I froze.

Whenever someone asked me what I wanted, my mind went blank. I would have the distinct thought that it didn't matter, that nothing would make me happy anyway. But when I received something not to my liking, I was incapable of rejecting it. I couldn't come out and say I didn't like it. Things I liked, I tasted with bitter fear, as if I were a thief, and then endured nameless dread. I lacked the strength to choose between two alternatives. This trait contributed greatly to what I refer to as my "life of much shame."

As I stood there fidgeting in silence, Father grew impatient. "What then, another book? You know, in a store in Asakusa I saw a lion mask, the kind they use in the New Year's lion dance, just the right size for a little boy. Wouldn't you like that?"

The words "Wouldn't you like that?" paralyzed me. I couldn't come up with any response, humorous or otherwise. I failed utterly in my role as jester.

"He'd probably like a book," said my oldest brother with a serious expression.

"A book, is it?" Father's smile faded in disappointment, and he slapped the notebook shut without writing anything down.

What a disaster! I had made Father angry, and he was sure to exact a terrible revenge. How could I set this right before it was too late? I lay quaking in my futon and racked my brains, then quietly got up, went into the living room and opened the desk drawer where I had seen Father put away the notebook. I took it out, flipped through the pages and, after finding the list of requests, licked the pencil attached to the notebook and wrote in big letters: LION MASK. Then I went back to bed. I didn't want a lion mask one bit. Even a book would have been better. But I realized that Father wanted to buy me the lion mask, and my desire to cater to his wish and restore his good humor led me to sneak into the living room in the dead of night.

That extreme gambit was rewarded with exactly the success I had hoped for. Before long Father came back from Tokyo, and from the children's

room I heard him say to Mother in a booming voice: “I opened up this notebook by the toy stand on Nakamise Street and look here, see, it says ‘LION MASK.’ That’s not my writing. I puzzled over it till the answer came to me: it’s Yozo, up to his tricks. When I asked him what he wanted, he just stood there grinning and didn’t say a word, but afterward he must have decided he had to have a lion mask. He’s a hard one to figure, the little rascal. Playing dumb, then writing it out like this. If he wanted a lion mask so much, all he had to do was say so! I laughed out loud in front of the toy stand. Send him in here right now.”

Then there was the time I gathered the servants in the Western-style room and had one of them bang on the keys of the piano (though we lived in the country, the house was furnished with pretty much all the amenities) while I danced like a wild Indian to that random melody and made everyone howl with laughter. My second-oldest brother took pictures with a flash attachment, and when they were developed, there between the folds of my loincloth (a calico wrapping cloth) was my weenie, which made everyone laugh all over again. I have to say this caper was another grand success.

I subscribed to a dozen or more monthly magazines for boys, and besides that I ordered all sorts of books from Tokyo and read them on my own, so I was well acquainted with Prof. Blumptyblump, Dr. Whosis and so on, and in addition I was well versed in ghost stories, tales of derring-do, funny stories and jokes. I had no shortage of material to draw from in order to amuse the family with deadpan recitals of funny stuff.

But oh, at school!

There, I was beginning to command respect. Being respected also scared me no end. To me it meant pulling the wool over the eyes of everyone around me only to be seen through by someone all-knowing and all-powerful who would blast me to smithereens, subject me to humiliation worse than death: that was how I defined the state of being respected. Even if I fooled everyone else into respecting me, one person would know the truth and sooner or later tell the others, who would then realize they had been fooled and in a rage inflict who knew what revenge. The very thought

was hair-raising.

The respect that came my way at school was owing not to the wealthy family I was born into but rather to my reputation as a whiz kid. Always a delicate child, I was often laid up with illness and would miss a month or two of classes or even the better part of an entire school year, yet when I recovered and rode back to school in a rickshaw to take the final exams, I would outperform everyone in my class. Even when my health was good, I did no studying whatever but spent my time drawing manga that I would explain to my classmates during recess to make them laugh. The compositions I wrote for the teacher consisted of comical anecdotes, and despite the teacher's cautions, I wouldn't stop writing them—I knew he secretly looked forward to reading them.

One time I wrote as usual about an epic failure, describing in tragic terms the time when, on the train to Tokyo with Mother, I mistakenly peed in an aisle spittoon. (I hadn't, however, been under any misapprehension about the nature of the spittoon; I'd acted knowingly, feigning childish innocence.) I turned in the paper, so certain it would make the teacher laugh that when he set off for the faculty room I followed along surreptitiously. As soon as he left the classroom, I saw him pull my composition out of the pile and begin to read it while walking, chuckling to himself. He must have come to the end before he entered the faculty room, for by then he was laughing hard, red in the face, and immediately began showing it to the other teachers. I was deeply satisfied.

A lovable scamp.

I succeeded in getting people to view me as a scamp. I succeeded in avoiding being an object of respect. On my report card, I received top grades in all subjects, but in deportment I would get only average or below, and this was another source of hilarity at home.

In truth, however, deep down I was not a scamp, but the polar opposite. Already by that time maids and menservants had taught me unspeakable things, done unspeakable things to me. I still believe that molesting a child is, of all the crimes humans can commit, the ugliest, vilest, cruelest crime

imaginable. But I endured it. I even felt as if I had come upon another human characteristic and weakly laughed it off. Had I been used to telling the truth, I might have been able to report those crimes to Father or Mother without flinching, but not even my parents made complete sense to me. I had no hope that anything would come of an appeal for help, whether to my father, my mother, a policeman or the government: in the end, I feared I would only be taken in by the slick excuses of people more skilled than I was at getting on in the world. The outcome would be unfair, that was a foregone conclusion. Since it was no use turning to others for help, all I could do was keep my mouth shut and endure, go on playing the clown. I felt I had no choice.

What's this, some may sneer, lack of faith in human beings? Since when did you become a Christian? But lack of faith in human beings does not necessarily lead directly to religion, or so it seems to me. It's clear that everyone, sneerers included, gets along just fine amid their mutual distrust without paying any heed to Jehovah or whoever.

One night when I was small, a famous man from my father's political party came to town to deliver a speech, and the servants took me to the theater to hear it. Every seat was filled, and everyone especially close to my father was there, clapping enthusiastically. When the speech ended, the crowd set off for home on the snowy road in clusters of three and five, ripping into the meeting as they walked. Some of the voices raised in criticism belonged to my father's special friends. Father's opening remarks were clumsy, the great man's speech was a pile of gibberish—Father's friends and associates said these things in angry, accusatory tones. Those same people then stopped by our house, went inside, and with expressions of apparent delight assured Father that the event had been a grand success. When Mother asked the servants their opinion, they said it was interesting without batting an eye. This from fellows who had complained to each other all the way home that lectures were the most boring thing in the world.

But that's only one example of human insincerity. Human life is, it seems to me, rife with vivid examples of an insincerity that is pure, happy and

serene—people deceiving one another without, amazingly, inflicting pain, without even realizing their mutual deception. But the deceptions themselves don't especially interest me. I myself deceive people from morning till night with my clowning. I can't get excited about textbook morality, the notion of doing what's "right." What confounds me is the spectacle of human beings who exude purity, happiness and serenity while engaged in deception, or who are confident in their ability to do so. I was never taught this deep secret. If I had only known that one thing, I would never have experienced such dread of human beings or felt such an urgent need to get on their good side. I wouldn't have been in such conflict with human life, wouldn't have gone through the torments of hell night after night. In short, the reason I never reported those foul crimes the servants committed against me had nothing to do with my distrust of human beings nor of course with Christian ethics; it was rather because people around me shut down my ability to trust anyone. Even my parents sometimes acted in ways I found hard to understand.

And I think the loneliness I embraced, unable to confide in anyone, gave off a scent that women picked up instinctively, and this was one reason why in later years I was taken advantage of in so many ways.

Women saw in me a man who could keep the secrets of love.

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Notebook Two

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第二の手記

Along the shore, close to the water’s edge, stood twenty or more rather tall cherry trees with ink-black trunks. Around the start of the school year in April, moist, reddish-brown new leaves would show against the blue sea, along with a glorious array of pale pink blossoms, and soon a storm of petals would arise and tumble into the water, where they would drift on the surface until waves carried them home. Despite having scarcely studied for the entrance exams, I somehow made it into a school whose territory included this petal-strewn beach. Stylized cherry blossoms bloomed on the emblem of the school cap and the buttons of the school uniform.

Distant relatives of ours lived around the corner, which was one reason Father kindly chose that school of sea and cherry blossoms for me. I went to live with them in a house so close to the school that even after the morning

bell rang I could make it on time if I ran. As this shows, I was a pretty lazy student, but thanks to my usual clowning, my popularity grew day by day.

I was living away from home for the first time, and life felt much easier. Perhaps this was because being a cutup had become second nature to me; I didn't have to work as hard at deceiving people. But more important, I think, was the deep-rooted difference between performing for family at home and for strangers in a strange place, a difference felt even by Jesus, the son of God. For an actor, the most challenging stage is in a hometown theater, especially with one's closest relatives in front-row seats; under those conditions, even a great thespian would be hard pressed to perform well. Yet I *had* performed well under those conditions, had achieved considerable success. How could anyone with that record of achievement possibly fail away from home?

Deep down, my dread of human beings still festered, but my clown act was smoother than ever. In the classroom, I was getting steady laughs, and although the teacher reprimanded me and said what a good class it would be if only I weren't there, behind his hand he was chuckling. I even got the military officer attached to the school, who had a gruff voice like thunder, to guffaw.

Just as I was beginning to feel relief at having successfully concealed my true self, I was stabbed in the back. As one might expect of a back-stabber, he was the class runt, with a gray puffy face and an outsize jacket that must have been a hand-me-down, the sleeves long and droopy like a throwback to ancient times, a dunce who was a flop at academics, a perennial bystander at military drill and in athletics class. I saw no reason to be on my guard around him.

That day, the boy (whose family name I can't recall, though I think his given name was Takeichi) sat looking on as usual while the rest of us were put through our paces on the horizontal bar. I deliberately affected the most solemn expression I could muster, let out a war whoop and rushed toward the bar, only to fly on past as if doing a broad jump and land with a thud on my butt in the sand. It was a calculated failure. Everyone roared with

laughter, exactly as I'd planned.

As I got up with an embarrassed smile and brushed the sand from my pants, Takeichi came up behind me—how long had he been hanging around there?—and poked me in the back. "On purpose," he whispered. "You did that on purpose."

I was severely shaken. Never had I dreamed that Takeichi, of all people, would be the one to perceive that I had deliberately flubbed it. In that moment, the world seemed to be engulfed in the flames of hellfire before my very eyes. It took all my strength to keep from crying out in a burst of madness.

Anxiety and fear ate at me in the days that followed. On the surface I kept up my wretched clowning and made everyone laugh, but now and again, I would sigh with the painful realization that no matter what I did, Takeichi would see straight through me, that before long he was bound to start letting everyone in on the truth. These thoughts brought on a panicky sweat, and I stared ahead with the vacant, roving eyes of a madman. If I could have, I would have liked to stick close to Takeichi morning, noon and night, keeping watch to prevent him from telling my secret and making every effort to convince him that my antics were not "on purpose" but genuine. I would even have liked to become best friends with him if I had the chance. And if none of that were possible, then I could only hope and pray that he would die. I have to say I never felt like killing him, though. Throughout my life, I have wished any number of times for someone to kill me, but never have I felt like killing someone. I always thought that challenging a formidable opponent with murder in my heart would only make the other fellow happy.

To win Takeichi over, I would put on a "nice" smile like a fake Christian and then, my head tilted at a disarming angle, put an arm around his small shoulders and in a syrupy, wheedling voice invite him over to play after school. He always looked at me blankly and said nothing. However, one day after classes, right around the beginning of summer, there was a sudden downpour. The other students were milling around, unable to leave, but

since I lived so close by I decided to make a dash for it. Then I happened to spot Takeichi standing disconsolately in the entranceway.

“Come on,” I said. “I’ll lend you my umbrella.”

He hesitated, so I grabbed him by the hand and we ran together through the rain. I asked my aunt to dry our wet clothes and then got him up the stairs to my room.

My widowed aunt, who was in her fifties, lived in the house with her two daughters. The elder daughter, Anesa, was a tall, bespectacled woman of about thirty whose health was poor (she had gone off once to be married but was now back again). The younger daughter, Setchan, had just graduated from a women’s college and was her sister’s opposite, short and moonfaced. The three of them ran a shop on the first floor selling stationery, sporting goods and whatnot, but their main source of income was rent money from the row house my uncle had left them.

“My ears hurt,” Takeichi said, standing there awkwardly. “They got wet in the rain and started hurting.”

I took a look. Both ears were badly infected and bursting with pus. “Oh no!” I said with an exaggerated show of surprise. “That must hurt a lot.” I took the blame, apologizing gently, like a girl: “I’m so sorry I dragged you out in the rain.”

I went downstairs and asked my aunt to give me some cotton balls and alcohol, then had Takeichi lie down with his head in my lap while I gave his ears a thorough cleaning. The hypocrisy and scheming behind my actions seemed to go right by him this time.

As he lay there with his head in my lap, he paid me this ignorant compliment: “I bet lots of girls’ll fall for you.”

In later years I was to discover what Takeichi could not have known, that this was a horrific, satanic prophecy. To “fall for” someone, to have them “fall for” you: either way, the expression sounds vulgar, facetious and grossly conceited. However solemn the occasion, once this expression rears its head, the temple of melancholy crumbles before your eyes, leaving a flat and featureless terrain. Yet replace “the pain of having someone fall for

you” with a more literary expression, say, “the anxiety of being loved,” and the temple of melancholy remains intact. It’s all very peculiar.

When I cleaned the discharge from Takeichi’s ears and he paid me that stupid compliment, I turned red and laughed it off without comment, but his words struck a faint chord within me. To admit that sounds appalling. It suggests an empty vanity, unworthy even of the young hero in a comic *rakugo* story. I don’t mean to imply that Takeichi’s words stirred any such absurd self-satisfaction.

Human females were many times harder for me to understand than males. They outnumbered males in my immediate family as well as among more distant relatives, and counting also the criminal maids, it’s fair to say that from the time I was small, my playmates all were girls; yet in fact, with girls I always felt I was on thin ice. I never knew what was coming. I’d be lost in a fog, and then I’d make some awful mistake and pay the price. Unlike the whipping a boy might mete out, the wound a girl inflicted was more like an internal hemorrhage, striking inward with extreme discomfort and slow to heal.

Girls drew you close and then pushed you away, or when other people were around they despised you, gave you a hard time, and then when everyone went away held you tight. Girls slept like the dead—sometimes I thought they lived to sleep. Since childhood I had observed all this and more. Though girls were evidently fellow members of the human race, they struck me as being utterly different from boys; and yet those inscrutable, untrustworthy creatures cared about me. To say that they “fell for” me or even that they “liked” me would be totally off the mark; the closest I can come is that they “cared about” me.

Girls, even more than boys, seemed at ease around a clown. When I pulled one of my stunts, boys didn’t go on laughing forever, and because I knew that if I overdid my clowning I’d fail, I was always careful to quit at an appropriate point. Girls, however, knew no moderation. They wanted me to keep clowning endlessly, and I would take up the challenge, providing encore after encore until I wore myself out. They really loved to laugh.

Girls had a greater capacity for fun than boys, it seemed to me.

The sisters would come up to my room every chance they got, and invariably I was startled and jumped in fear.

“Are you studying?” one of them would ask.

“No,” I’d say with a smile and close my book. “Today at school our geography teacher, old Kombo . . .” I’d be off and running, telling funny stories even though my heart wasn’t in it.

One evening they came to see me and, after making me clown around for quite some time, begged me to put on a pair of glasses.

“What for?”

“Just do it, will you? Put hers on,” said Setchan, who was always issuing curt commands.

The clown did as he was told. Instantly, the two of them went into a fit of giggles.

“He looks just like him! He looks just like Lloyd!” Harold Lloyd, a foreign film comedian, was then popular in Japan.

I stood up and struck a pose. “Ladies and gentlemen! I would just like to say to all my fans in Japan . . .” They laughed even harder. From then on, every time a Harold Lloyd film came to town, I would go see it and secretly study his expressions and mannerisms.

One evening in the fall, I was lying down reading a book when Anesa came flying into my room like a bird and collapsed, sobbing, on top of my futon.

“Yo-chan, you’ve got to help me! You will, won’t you? I’d be better off leaving this awful place with you. Help me. Help me!” She babbled hysterically and then dissolved in tears again.

This wasn’t the first time I had seen a woman in such a state. I wasn’t particularly surprised at her emotional outburst; its very banality and insignificance cooled any interest I might have had. Cautiously I got up, peeled and cut up a persimmon on my desk and handed her a slice.

She ate it and said, hiccuping, “Have you got any amusing books? Let me borrow one.”

I selected Soseki's *I Am a Cat* from the shelf and gave it to her. She thanked me with an embarrassed smile and left the room.

For me, trying to imagine the feelings not just of my cousin but of women in general was more confusing, troublesome and vaguely unsettling than probing the psyches of earthworms would have been. All I knew for certain, based on a lifetime of experience, was that when a female bursts into tears like that, if you give her something sweet, she'll eat it and recover her spirits.

Setchan, the younger one, would bring her friends to my room, and after I had as always entertained them without showing any partiality and they had gone home, she would unfailingly lay into them. "So-and-so is a juvenile delinquent, so watch out for her." (Then why bring her to my room in the first place?) In any case, thanks to Setchan, almost all of the visitors to my room were female.

This was by no means a fulfillment of Takeichi's prediction. No, I was merely the Tohoku version of Harold Lloyd. Several years would pass before Takeichi's ignorant compliment predicting my future popularity with the opposite sex took on new life, proving itself a sinister prophecy.

Takeichi gave me one other important gift. One time when he came over, he proudly showed off the full-color reproduction of a frontispiece he had brought along. "It's a picture of a monster."

His words took me by surprise. In later years I would became convinced that my path in life was settled in that moment. I knew very well that this was van Gogh's famous self-portrait. When we were boys, French Impressionist works were hugely popular, serving as stepping-stones to an appreciation of Western art. Even provincial middle schoolers like us were generally familiar with photogravure reproductions of the works of Van Gogh, Gaugin, Cézanne, Renoir and others. I had seen plenty of color reproductions of the paintings of Van Gogh, and I was attracted to the vitality of his touch and the brilliance of his colors, but never once had I thought he painted monsters.

"What about this? Is this a monster, too?" I took down a Modigliani

album from the shelf and showed Takeichi the famous painting of a nude woman with skin the color of burnt gold-copper.

“Wow!” he exclaimed, eyes popping. “She’s like a horse from hell, with a human face.”

“So, a monster?”

“I want to draw pictures of monsters like these,” said Takeichi.

People terrified of other human beings want to feast their eyes on monsters that are even more terrifying, the way nervous and easily intimidated people pray for the storm to rage ever more wildly. This group of painters, having been wounded and threatened by human monsters, finally believed their fantasies, saw them vividly in broad daylight and sought to express exactly what they had seen, not resorting to clowning but, as Takeichi had said, resolutely drawing “pictures of monsters.” These were my future comrades, I thought to myself in tearful excitement.

“I’ll draw them, too,” I told Takeichi in a half whisper. “I’ll draw pictures of monsters, the horses of hell.”

From the time I was in elementary school, I had always liked drawing and looking at pictures, but the pictures I drew didn’t attract as much praise as my essays. Because I put no faith whatever in human language, I saw my essays as merely a clown’s hello, a way of tickling my teachers, devoid of personal interest. I did, however, take pains in my own childish way with the pictures I painted (manga were another matter). The drawings we were given to copy in art class were boring and the teacher’s work was lousy, so I was forced to experiment randomly on my own using a variety of artistic methods. In middle school I acquired all the tools I needed for oil painting, but although I turned to the Impressionists for guidance, my paintings came out as flat and expressionless as paper cutouts and didn’t amount to anything.

Then Takeichi’s comments made me realize that my whole approach to art was wrong. In striving to represent things that I thought beautiful as precisely that, beautiful, I had been naïve and foolish. The masters used to create beauty out of insignificant things, relying on their own

interpretations, and while revolted by ugly things, they did not hide their fascination but reveled in the joy of creativity. In short, they didn't rely in the least on others' expectations. After Takeichi granted me this primitive guide to artistic expression, little by little and in secret from the female visitors to my room, I worked on a self-portrait.

The finished painting was shockingly gloomy, even to me. Yet this was the true self I kept hidden away. On the surface, I laughed cheerfully and entertained people, while all the time my heart was dark and brooding—so naturally the self-portrait was, too, I told myself in secret affirmation. Still, I showed it only to Takeichi. I didn't want others to discover the gloom lurking beneath my clowning exterior and become suddenly wary of me. I was apprehensive that instead of seeing my true self, they might see my self-portrait as a new form of clowning and make it the butt of their jokes—excruciating thought—so I quickly stuck the painting in the back of my closet.

In art class, I kept the "monster method" to myself and went on representing beautiful things beautifully, with the same mediocre result as before.

I had always shown Takeichi my vulnerable, hypersensitive side without any hesitation, and I showed him the self-portrait in a relaxed mood. He praised it highly. I kept on drawing a few more pictures of monsters and was rewarded with this prophecy: "Someday you'll be a great painter."

With two prophecies from that ninny Takeichi emblazoned on my brow —"lots of girls'll fall for you" and "someday you'll be a great painter"—I set off for Tokyo.

I wanted to go to art school, but Father had long wanted to send me to university with an eye to my becoming a government official. He told me this and I—unable as ever to talk back to him—obeyed in a daze. He urged me to apply early, and since I was tired of the sea-and-cherry-blossom school, I went to Tokyo a whole year before graduating, sat for the university entrance exam and passed. I moved straight into the dormitory, but it was so disgustingly dirty and uncivilized that I had a doctor issue a

medical certificate stating I had TB and relocated to my father's house in Ueno. Group life was beyond me. Also, references to the thrills or pride of youth left me cold; I couldn't work up any school spirit. The classrooms and dormitory both struck me as dumps for a twisted kind of sexual desire, places where my expert clowning served no purpose.

Father stayed in that house only a week or two when the Diet wasn't in session, and while he was away I had the spacious house nearly to myself, along with an elderly caretaker couple. I skipped school a lot but didn't feel much like sightseeing in Tokyo, either (in all likelihood I will die without having seen Meiji Shrine, the statue of Kusunoki Masashige or the graves of the forty-seven ronin), and spent my days at home, reading or painting. When Father was in town I would scuttle off to school every morning—not to the university but to the painting school of the Western-style painter Shintaro Yasuda, in Hongo, sometimes spending as much as three or four hours there practicing sketching. After moving out of the school dormitory, even if I went to class I felt like someone in a special position, an auditor, although that could have been a preconceived notion on my part. I came to feel like a barefaced hypocrite, and going to school seemed more trouble than it was worth. Throughout elementary school, middle school and college, "school spirit" was beyond my comprehension. I never even tried to learn a school song.

Eventually, Masao Horiki, a fellow student at the painting school, introduced me to drinking, smoking, prostitutes, pawnshops and leftist thought. A strange assortment, but that's the real list. Horiki, who hailed from Tokyo's old downtown area, was six years older than me; he had graduated from a private art school but had no studio at home and was now continuing his study of Western-style painting at Yasuda's school.

"Lend me five yen, please," he said one day. We knew each other by sight only and until then had never exchanged a word. Flustered, I handed him the money.

"Great. Let's go drinking. It's my treat. You're a good kid."

Unable to fend him off, I let him drag me to a nearby hostess bar, and that

was the start of our friendship.

“I’ve had my eye on you for some time. That’s it, yeah, that shy smile, that’s the expression of a promising young artist. Here’s to new friends. Cheers! Kinu,” he said to the hostess, “isn’t he handsome? Don’t fall for him, now. Ever since he started coming to the painting class, I’ve sadly become second handsomest.”

Horiki had a dark complexion and even features; unusually for an art student, he wore a proper suit with a conservative necktie and his hair was parted in the middle, slicked down with pomade.

The unfamiliar place terrified me, so I folded and unfolded my arms with what probably did look like a shy smile frozen on my face, but after a couple or three beers I felt a lightness, an odd sense of liberation.

“I’ve been thinking of enrolling in art school for real,” I said.

“Don’t waste your time. Places like that are a waste of time. School’s a waste of time. If we seek a teacher, we must look to Nature! Ah, what pathos there is in our response to Nature!”

I took little account of what he said. I thought he was a fool and surely not much of an artist, but possibly someone good to go out on the town with. For the first time in my life, I had encountered a genuine city wastrel. In a different way from me, Horiki, too, was completely detached from the doings of ordinary human beings, had lost his bearings; in that respect, we were kindred spirits. Yet there was an essential dissimilarity between us: he was a buffoon without realizing it and was, moreover, completely unaware of the wretchedness of his buffoonery.

I felt scornful of him, always telling myself that I was with him only to go out on the town, that he was someone to pass the time with, no more; I was even ashamed of my friendship with him. But as he and I spent more time walking around together, he, too, finally broke me down completely.

In the beginning, though, I was convinced he was a fine fellow—singularly fine—and despite my habitual fear of human beings I let down my guard around him, pleased to have found a guide to the city. Alone, when I rode the train I was afraid of the conductor, when I went to see

kabuki I was afraid of the usherettes standing on either side of the red-carpeted staircase at the entrance, and when I went to a restaurant I was afraid of the waiter standing silently behind me waiting for me to clean my plate. Above all, when I went to pay the bill, my gestures were unbearably awkward. Anytime I handed over money for a purchase, I became dizzy not from stinginess but from an attack of nerves, shame, anxiety, terror: everything went dark, and I would be in such a panic that far from haggling over the price, I would forget my change, forget even to take my purchase with me more often than not. Navigating Tokyo on my own was impossible, and instead I would stay home all day, lying around doing nothing.

But when I handed my wallet over to Horiki and went around town with him, he haggled mightily and took charge of our adventures with aplomb, demonstrating an impressive ability to use a slight amount of money for maximum effect. He avoided expensive taxis, preferring the train, bus, riverboat and so on, always seeing to it that we arrived at our destination in minimum time. On the way home from a brothel early in the morning, at his recommendation we would stop off at an inn where I absorbed the practical lesson that a morning bath, a dish of simmered tofu and vegetables, and a bit of sake could make you feel as though you were living a life of luxury while costing next to nothing. He also taught me that roadside stalls sold cheap, nutritious foods like yakitori and gyumeshi, rice covered with beef and vegetables, and he swore that nothing got you drunk faster than Denki Bran, a cocktail of brandy, gin, wine, curacao and assorted herbs. Never once did he make me feel anxious or scared about the bill for our adventures.

Horiki had another saving grace: during our rambles about town, he showed complete disregard for my opinions and constantly went on about what he called “pathos” (perhaps pathos entails ignoring the feelings of one’s companion?) in stupid, endless rants that eliminated any need for me to fear that as we tired of walking we might fall into awkward silences. In my interactions with people, fear of those horrendous silences—a fear all the greater because I spoke slowly—had driven me to play the clown in

desperation, as if my life depended on it, but now stupid Horiki took on that role without even realizing it, allowing me to listen without concentrating on what he said. All I had to do was keep smiling and slip in an occasional “No kidding!”

Drink, tobacco, prostitutes: I soon came to see that these were all excellent ways of dissipating, however briefly, my dread of humans. I even came to feel that selling off all my possessions in the pursuit of these dissipations would be worth it.

Prostitutes seemed to me to be neither people nor women, but idiots or lunatics. In the arms of a prostitute I could sleep soundly, completely at ease. Prostitutes were utterly, painfully, lacking in wants. And perhaps they sensed that I was one of them, a kindred spirit, for they invariably showed me a warmth that was never oppressive. A warmth without calculation or hidden agenda, a warmth toward someone who might never return: some nights, I saw the halo of Mary hovering over those prostitutes akin to idiots or lunatics.

Seeking to escape my dread of humans and just find a night’s rest, I took to spending more and more time with those kindred spirits of mine and thereby unknowingly acquired a completely unanticipated “extra”—a certain scandalous aura. It was Horiki who made me aware of the change, his comments leaving me astonished and disgruntled. Any objective observer could see that my schooling in women came from prostitutes and that my skills with women had recently shown great improvement—hardly surprising, he assured me, as the rigorous training of prostitutes produced the best results. I now gave off the heady aroma of “lady-killer,” an aroma that women (not only prostitutes) instinctively picked up on and gravitated toward. This indecent and inglorious atmosphere, the “extra” I had acquired, far eclipsed the restorative effects of my training.

Horiki said these things partly to flatter me, I suppose, but I pondered his words with a heavy heart, feeling their truth. A woman in a hostess bar had written me a clumsy letter; every morning as I set off for school, the daughter of the general next door, a young woman of about twenty, would

go in and out of her gate for no apparent reason, wearing a touch of makeup; when I went out for a steak, without a word of encouragement from me the waitress would . . . ; the girl in the tobacco shop I frequented handed me a pack of cigarettes that contained . . . ; when I went to a kabuki performance, the girl in the seat next to mine . . . Then there was the time I was drunkenly dozing on the streetcar late one night and . . . ; the time when out of the blue I received a passionate letter from the daughter of relatives back home; the time when some girl anonymously left me a doll she had made herself. Since I was passive in the extreme, nothing came of any of these incidents, but there was no denying that something about me caused women to dream dreams; I was neither boasting nor making coarse jokes in acknowledging this. That someone like Horiki first brought this to my attention flooded me with a bitterness close to humiliation and dampened my enthusiasm for frequenting prostitutes.

Another time, to show off his “modernity” (I couldn’t then and can’t now think of any other reason why Horiki would do this) he took me to a secret Communist meeting (it was called a Reading Society or something; I don’t really remember). He may have simply lumped secret Communist meetings in with all the other sights of Tokyo. I was introduced to the “comrades” and made to buy a pamphlet, after which we heard a lecture on Marxist economics by the guest of honor, a young man with extremely ugly features whose every word struck me as patently obvious. What he said was no doubt true, and yet I knew the human heart was far more unfathomable, more terrifying than that. Greed wasn’t the half of it, nor vanity. Lust and greed together didn’t come close to an explanation.

Though my thoughts were imprecise, I sensed that the bedrock of human society wasn’t simply economics but something weirdly monstrous. I found this idea so disturbing that while I accepted materialism as naturally as water finds its own level, my dread of human beings did not therefore diminish nor did I take to gazing wide-eyed at new leaves with a joyous welling of hope. But I faithfully attended meetings of the Reading Society (if that’s what it was called; I could be wrong). I looked on with amusement

at comrades absorbed in the study of economic theories on the level of “one plus one equals two,” their expressions so grave you’d have thought they were debating matters of life and death. Resorting to my usual antics, I tried to lighten the mood, and gradually the oppressively formal meetings loosened up. I actually became quite popular and indispensable to the group.

Those simple people may have thought I was just as simple as they were, an optimistic comrade always good for a laugh, but if so I was wholly deceiving them: I was *not* their comrade. But I attended their meetings without fail and obligingly entertained them as a clown.

I did it because I was enjoying myself. Those people appealed to me. That wasn’t the same as bonding over Marx, however.

Illegality: the notion was faintly pleasurable, even comfortable. I found society’s laws terrifying (suggestive of unlimited power), their mechanism incomprehensible. They made society a windowless room of penetrating cold where I could not bear to remain. Outside might be a sea of illegality, but it seemed a far easier choice to dive into those forbidden waters and swim until I drowned.

People speak of “outcasts,” a term that apparently refers to wretched losers and rogues. I feel I have been an outcast since the day I was born. Whenever I encounter someone whom society has branded an outcast, my heart softens, becomes so tender and mild that I could swoon.

People speak also of a “sense of wrongdoing.” All my life in human society I have suffered from that sense. Like a wife who sticks by her husband through thick and thin, a sense of wrongdoing has been my faithful companion, and our private, cheerless frolicking has amounted to a way of life for me.

I have also heard people speak of the “wound of a guilty conscience.” That wound has been part of me since my birth, not healing as I grew but rather digging down to the bone, plunging me into the nightly hell of endlessly shifting torments, and yet—peculiar though it may sound—gradually becoming dearer to me than my flesh and my blood. In time the

pain has come to resemble the wound's emotion at being alive, even its whispered endearments.

To such a man as I was, the atmosphere created by that underground group was oddly reassuring and comforting. In other words, I felt at home not with the movement's intended purpose but with its disposition. Horiki, on the other hand, used the movement only for mindless fun; after the meeting where he introduced me he never went back, making the stupid joke that Marxists needed to study not just the means of production but the means of consumption, too. At any rate, his invitations to me had to do exclusively with the latter.

Looking back, I would say that at the time, Marxists came in a variety of flavors. Some, like Horiki, styled themselves as such out of a vain sense of modernity, while others, like me, were passive participants attracted by the whiff of illegality. Any true believer who saw through us would have flown into a rage, branded the pair of us dirty traitors, and thrown us out on the spot. But neither he nor I was ever expelled from the movement. That illegal world was congenial to me, more so than the world of law-abiding gentlemen, and in it I was able to relax and conduct myself in a "healthy" way that made them look on me as a promising comrade. They took to asking me to run all sorts of errands, always in an excessively hush-hush manner that made me want to burst out laughing. I never refused any assignment and carried them all off with such aplomb that the "dogs" (the comrades' name for the police) suspected nothing and never so much as hauled me in for questioning. Always laughing and getting laughs, I carried out with precision what the comrades referred to as "dangerous missions." (Those in the movement treated everything with life-and-death gravity and took elaborate precautions that resembled a bad imitation of a detective story; the jobs I took on were astounding in their insignificance, but everyone made a big deal of them, as if they entailed high peril.)

At the time I felt that even if I were to become a party member, get caught and end up spending the rest of my life in prison, I would be fine. Prison might well be an improvement on groaning night after night in the perdition

of insomnia, fearing the realities of life as lived by humans in this world.

Though Father and I shared the house in Ueno, he was so often out or entertaining visitors that we could go three or four days at a stretch without seeing each other. I found him unapproachable and formidable, and though I wished I could leave and find lodgings somewhere else, I hesitated to broach the topic. Before I had a chance to do so, I heard from the old caretaker that Father intended to sell the house.

He was nearing the end of his term in the Diet, and there were undoubtedly a host of reasons for the decision. He didn't seem to want to run for office again; back home he was building a retirement retreat; and, having no particular attachment to Tokyo, he possibly considered it wasteful to maintain a household and servants for the sake of a mere student like myself (as with people's feelings, I couldn't fathom thought processes either). In any case, the house soon passed into the hands of its new owner, and I went to live in an old lodging-house in Hongo—and promptly ran out of money.

Until then, Father had given me a monthly allowance that I used up in a few days, but cigarettes, alcohol, cheese and fruit were always available at home, and books, writing materials and clothing I could purchase from local stores on credit. In the neighborhood restaurant where Father was a regular, I could treat Horiki to a bowl of noodles, or rice topped with deep-fried prawns and vegetables, and never pay a penny.

Now all of a sudden I was out on my own, forced to meet all my expenses out of my monthly allowance. As before, the money evaporated in two or three days, leaving me horrified, helpless and panicky. I would fire off telegrams and follow-up letters to my father, brothers and sisters in turn, begging for assistance (the circumstances I described in the letters were invariably fictionalized, presented in a tone of frivolity; I figured that when asking someone for something, it was best to begin by getting a laugh). Under Horiki's guidance I took to frequenting pawnshops, but even so, I was always hard up for cash.

In short, I lacked the ability to live on my own without connections.

Sitting huddled alone in my room felt terrifying, as if at any moment I might be attacked, perhaps hit on the head, so I would rush out to help with the movement or go drinking cheap liquor with Horiki, abandoning my schoolwork and my painting, both. Then in the November of my second year in college, I formed a double suicide pact with a married woman, and my life turned upside down.

Although I didn't ever go to class or study, somehow I seemed able to come up with passable answers to exam questions, and so far I had been able to fool my family back home. Now, however, the school sent my father a confidential report of my failure to meet attendance requirements, among other things, and I began receiving a stream of long, sternly worded letters from my eldest brother, written in Father's stead. There were also more direct sources of pain: my lack of money and the fact that my service to the movement had become so intense and all-absorbing that I could no longer do it half in fun. I was in charge of Marxist student action groups in schools throughout central Tokyo, in the districts of Hongo, Koishikawa, Shitaya and Kanda. In case of an armed uprising, I bought a small knife (I later realized its delicate blade was barely strong enough to sharpen pencils) that I carried around in my raincoat pocket while I busied myself doing "liaison" work.

I wanted to have a drink and fall sound asleep, but I had no money. Moreover, orders from P (our code name for the Party, as I recall, though again I could be wrong) came in such a cascade that I scarcely had time to breathe. My sickly body couldn't keep up. All along I had only been helping out because the group's illegal status appealed to me, but what had started as a joke was now all too real. Unbearably busy, I felt like telling the P leadership, *You've got the wrong guy. Why not have an actual member do your dirty work?* Unable to suppress my hateful thoughts, I fled. When fleeing didn't make me feel any better, I decided to end it all.

At the time, there were three women who had feelings for me. One was my landlord's daughter. Every time I came back exhausted after helping with the movement and collapsed on my futon without supper, she would

show up in my room, pen and writing paper in hand: “May I come in? My sister and brother make so much noise downstairs, I can’t focus on this letter I’m writing.” Then she would sit at my desk and write for an hour or more.

All I had to do was ignore her and go back to sleep, but she so clearly wanted me to talk to her that my passive urge to please kicked in. Even though I didn’t want to utter a word, I rolled over onto my stomach with great effort and took a drag on a cigarette.

“I heard there’s a guy who heats his bathwater by burning love letters from women.”

“No! I bet it’s you.”

“I once heated a cup of milk that way and drank it down.”

“I would consider it an honor. Use mine next, won’t you?”

If only she’d go away and leave me alone! Writing a letter? A likely story. Scribbling random nonsense, I’d have bet.

“Let me see it,” I said, though seeing what she had written was the last thing in the world I wanted to do. She lit up with pleasure and protested in a coy manner so disgraceful I lost all interest in her. Then I came up with an idea: I would send her on an errand.

“I hate to ask you this, but would you mind going out to the pharmacy and picking me up some Calmotine? I’m worn out, my face is hot and I can’t sleep. I’d really appreciate it. The money is—”

“Oh, don’t you worry about the money.” She gladly got up.

I knew very well that women aren’t put off when asked to run an errand, that they quite like having a man ask them to do some little thing for him.

Another woman attracted to me was a student in a teacher-training college, a “comrade” whom I had no choice but to see daily, like it or not. After a meeting to plan the day’s activities, she would tag along and buy me this and that.

“Just think of me as your real sister,” she would say, and I’d force a sad smile, inwardly shuddering at her affected ways.

“I do, I do.”

Afraid of making the ugly, unlikable woman angry, I avoided leveling with her and ended up yielding to her whims. When she bought me something (invariably in atrocious taste; I usually handed off whatever it was to a street vendor or the like), I would look pleased and offer a quip to make her laugh. One summer night on a dark street corner, she was being especially clingy, and, desperate to be rid of her, I kissed her. She became shamefully, wildly impassioned, hailed a cab and took me to a little office that the movement secretly rented, where we whooped it up till morning.

That's one hell of a sister, I told myself with a wry smile.

With both the landlord's daughter and this "comrade," our forced close contact left me no way to escape, as I had done with so many women in the past, and so things dragged on, my old insecurity compelling me to cozy up to them both. I felt paralyzed, unable to extricate myself.

Around that same time, a woman working in a big hostess bar on the Ginza strip did me an unexpected favor, and even though we had met only once, my awareness of what I owed her filled me with concern and terror. By then, I had equipped myself with sufficient brazenness to ride the streetcar, see kabuki or stroll into a hostess bar alone, even without Horiki to shepherd me.

In my heart, I still distrusted and feared the confidence and the violence of human beings, but little by little I had grown able, on the surface, to meet people and talk to them properly with a straight face—or no, I take it back, it wasn't in me to meet people without affecting the defeated, strained smile of a buffoon. Yet somehow I had learned to engage in small talk, even if I did sound overwrought and flustered. Did I owe this change to the work I'd done on behalf of the movement? To women? To drinking? More than anything, I owed it to being perennially broke. I lived in a state of constant fear, and one day it occurred to me that if I could go to a big hostess bar and lose myself amid the jostle of drunken patrons, hostesses and busboys, I might relax and find relief from the sense of being pursued.

With that hope in mind, I went into the aforementioned establishment with just ten yen and told the hostess with a laugh,

“I’ve only got ten yen on me. Thought you ought to know.”

“No need to worry.”

I detected a bit of western Japan in her speech. Her comment had a peculiarly calming effect on my shakiness and agitation—and no, it wasn’t that I no longer feared coming up short on the bill. I actually felt that as long as I was with her, there *was* no need to worry.

I ordered a drink. The hostess had earned my trust and I felt no need to clown around, so I let my true character, gloomy and taciturn, show as I drank in silence.

“Want any of these?” She spread out an assortment of appetizers.

I shook my head.

“Just a drink? I’ll have one, too.”

It was a cold autumn night. I went to the back-alley sushi stall where Tsuneko (I think she was called Tsuneko, but my recollection has faded and I can’t be certain; I am the sort of man who forgets the name of the woman he agreed to commit double suicide with) had said she would meet me after work. While I was waiting for her, I ate some sushi that tasted bad. (I may have forgotten her name, but for some reason I can clearly recall the bad taste of that sushi. I also have a vivid mental picture of the old bald guy with a face like a rat snake, swinging his head from side to side while he hand-rolled sushi with flair, making himself look as if he knew what he was doing. In later years, more than once I would be riding the streetcar, catch sight of a familiar-looking face and, after racking my brain, realize *Oh yeah, he looks like the sushi guy that time* and smile wryly to myself. When her name and even her face are vanishing from my memory, why do I still remember the sushi guy’s face so precisely that I could draw it? I believe it’s because of his bad-tasting sushi, which chilled and disturbed me. Then again, even when taken to a famous sushi restaurant, I was never impressed. The pieces of sushi were always too big. I would think, *Why can’t they make them the size of a thumb, the way they’re supposed to be?*)

She was living in a rented room on the second floor of a carpenter’s house in Honjo. I lay on the tatami and sipped a cup of tea, one hand propping up

my cheek as if I were suffering from a toothache, making no attempt to hide my disconsolation. This posture seemed to meet with her approval. She struck me as totally isolated, a woman standing amid a swirl of dead leaves, whipped by a cold wind.

As we lay there side by side, she told me her story. She was two years older than me, married, from Hiroshima. “I’ve got a husband. He used to be a barber in Hiroshima, and last spring we ran away together to Tokyo. He never found a real job, and after a while he was charged with fraud and sent to prison. I’ve been going to see him every day, taking him whatever he needs, but from tomorrow I’ll stop.”

Unfortunately, somehow women’s life stories never interest me, perhaps because women aren’t very good at telling them; they emphasize the wrong points. At any rate, I always turn a deaf ear.

I feel so sad and alone.

Those few words murmured in my ear would arouse my sympathies more than any rambling sob story. I find it bizarre and astonishing that no woman has ever spoken them to me. Neither did she, but her body was wrapped in a thin current of sadness and loneliness that wrapped around me, too, when I nestled against her, merging with my own current of prickly gloom and enabling me, like a withered leaf settling on a rock at the river bottom, to let go of my fear and anxiety.

This was completely different from the feeling of ease that enabled me to sleep soundly in the arms of idiot prostitutes. (For one thing, the prostitutes were cheerful.) That night with the wife of a convicted criminal was, for me, a night of liberation and happiness (an outlandish word that I do not expect to use again in this notebook in such an assured and affirmative way).

But those feelings were to last for only one night. The next morning I awoke, jumped up and reverted to the same flippant clown act as always. To the weak, even feeling happy can be frightening. We can injure ourselves with cotton balls, get hurt by happiness. Anxious to end things before disaster struck, I put up the usual smoke screen of buffoonery.

“When poverty comes in at the door, love flies out at the window, they say, but the popular interpretation is all wrong. The proverb doesn’t mean that when your money’s gone, your woman will walk out. When a man runs out of money, you see, naturally he loses heart, goes into a deep funk. His laugh is hollow and he becomes strangely paranoid, until finally, in desperation, he walks out and keeps right on going, never looks back. That’s what it says in the Kanazawa Dictionary. It’s a damn shame, though I can imagine the feeling.”

I remember spouting some such nonsense and making Tsuneko burst out laughing. Nothing good could come of my hanging around, so I made tracks, not even staying long enough to splash water on my face. My irresponsible remarks would later give rise to an unexpected complication.

I didn’t see my benefactor of that night for another month. After I left her, my happiness waned day by day, and the slight kindness she had done me began to fill me with alarm. For no reason, I began to feel the shackles of obligation, and the simple fact that I had made Tsuneko pay my entire bill that night weighed on me until in my mind she was no different from the landlord’s daughter or the girl at the teacher-training college, just another threatening female, and despite the distance between us, I lived in constant fear. Moreover, I had the overpowering conviction that any woman I had once slept with would turn on me in a fury if we met again, so that in my reluctance to see her, I gave the Ginza a wide berth. My reluctance wasn’t a result of craftiness on my part but rather rose out of my failure to fully grasp a curious phenomenon: women maintain not a speck of connection between what happens after they go to bed and what happens after they get up in the morning but live in two worlds as cleanly cut off from one another as if by the river of oblivion.

Late in November, I was drinking cheap liquor with Horiki at a bar in Kanda, and when we left, that evil friend of mine insisted we continue drinking. Neither of us had any money, but that didn’t stop him.

“Come on, let’s go somewhere else and drink some more!”

Drunk, feeling reckless, I gave in. “All right then, follow me to the land

of dreams. Hold on to your hat. Get ready for a night of revelry and feasting like you've never—"

"You mean a hostess bar?"

"I do."

"Let's go!"

We boarded a streetcar.

Horiki was in high spirits. "I'm hungry for a woman tonight. Okay if I kiss a hostess?" I didn't much like it when he put on that sort of drunken act, and he knew it, so he pressed the point. "All right? I'm kissing a hostess, I tell you. Wait and see. Whoever comes and sits beside me is getting herself kissed but good."

"It's not a problem."

"Thanks! I'm starved for a woman."

We got off the streetcar at Ginza Yonchome and entered that same hostess bar, the palace of revelry and feasting. I had barely a penny on me; Tsuneko was my only hope. Horiki and I found a vacant booth and sat across from each other, and she and another hostess came scurrying over. The other one sat next to me, and Tsuneko plopped down beside Horiki. Then it hit me: she was moments away from being kissed.

I didn't feel resentful. I'm not possessive by nature. On occasion, I might feel a faint pang when someone takes something that belongs to me, but I lack the energy to assert my rights by starting a fight. Later in my life, I would even look on in silence as my wife was sexually assaulted.

As far as possible, I strove to steer clear of human complications. The mere thought of getting sucked into that whirlpool terrified me. Tsuneko and I had shared a single night. She did not belong to me. I had no right to feel anything as arrogant as resentment. And yet I was shocked.

This was because I felt sorry for Tsuneko, about to receive a ferocious kiss from Horiki right in front of me. Once tarnished in that way, she would no doubt have to leave me. I lacked the fierce passion to make her stay. *It's all over now*, I thought, and although her misfortune gave me a momentary shock, I soon accepted the inevitable, accommodating myself to the

situation with the ease of water flowing around something in its way. I looked from Horiki to Tsuneko and grinned.

But all at once the situation took a wholly unexpected turn—a turn for the worse.

“I’m done!” Horiki frowned. “This one looks too pathetic, reeks too much of poverty, even for me.” He crossed his arms and stared at Tsuneko in apparent disgust, his mouth twisted in a crooked smile.

“Get us some drinks,” I told Tsuneko in a low voice. “We have no money.” I wanted to drown myself in alcohol. In the eyes of a man of the world, Tsuneko wasn’t even worthy of drunken kisses, she was only a pathetic woman who reeked of poverty. This discovery caught me completely off guard, left me thunderstruck.

I kept on drinking, more and more as never before, getting smashed. Tsuneko and I traded sad smiles. *Yeah, I see it now, that’s all she is, a weird, worn-out woman who stinks of poverty*. At the same time, as a fellow pauper I felt drawn to her (the discord between rich and poor may seem hackneyed, but I now believe it to be one of the eternal dramatic themes), and that attraction, that sense of closeness, came welling up, endearing her to me and making me sense for the first time in my life the positive, if faint, stirrings of love. I threw up. Lost consciousness. That was the first time in my life I ever drank so much that I passed out.

When I woke up, Tsuneko was sitting by my pillow. I had been asleep in her room in the carpenter’s house in Honjo.

“When you said poverty at the door makes love fly out at the window, I thought you were joking, but I guess you meant it. You never came back. It’s a messy business, the end of love. Would it make any difference if I earned money for the both of us?”

“No.”

Then she lay down, too, and toward dawn the word “death” passed her lips for the first time. She seemed exhausted by human affairs, and I was frazzled by fear of society, hassles, money, the movement, women, my studies . . . the more I thought about it, the less I felt I could bear to on

living, and when she suggested that we commit suicide together, I readily agreed.

But at that time I hadn't really made up my mind to die. There was still an element of pretend in it all.

That morning, we walked around Asakusa together. We went into a coffee shop and had hot milk.

"You pay, will you?" she said.

I stood up, took out my wallet and opened it. Three copper coins. It was not shame that flowed through me but horror. I pictured my room at the lodging-house, now containing only my school uniform and futon, a barren room devoid of anything worth pawning. My only other possessions were the kimono and cloak I had on. This was the bitter truth. Obviously, I could not go on living.

As I stood there flustered, she got up and peered inside my wallet. "Is that all you've got?"

Her voice was innocent, but her words cut to my heart. My pain was all the greater because this was the voice of the first woman I had ever loved. Yes, it was all I had, and it was nothing; three copper coins hardly counted as money. I felt a peculiar humiliation beyond any I had ever known, a humiliation I could not live with. I suppose I had yet to shed my sense of myself as the pampered scion of a rich family. At this, I made the conscious decision, on my own, to die.

That night, we jumped into the sea at Kamakura. She first took off her obi sash, which she said she had borrowed from a friend, folded it and laid it on a rock. I took off my cloak and laid it in the same place, and we went into the water together.

She died. I alone was saved.

The newspapers made much of the incident, probably because I was a college student and my father's name still retained some news value.

I was admitted to a hospital on the coast. A family member rushed to my side, saw to a great many details and returned home after informing me that the entire family from Father on down was furious with me and I might well

end up being disowned. I didn’t care. I longed for the dead Tsuneko and couldn’t stop weeping. Of all my relationships, the only person I had truly loved was Tsuneko, a woman who reeked of poverty.

The landlord’s daughter sent me a long letter containing fifty tanka poems, all starting with the odd first line, “Live for me, do.” Nurses took to popping into my sickroom to say a cheerful hello, and some would squeeze my hand before leaving.

They discovered at the hospital that my left lung had been damaged, which worked greatly to my advantage when the police came. I was charged with assisting a suicide and escorted from the hospital, but at the station they treated me as an invalid and put me in an isolation room, away from the other prisoners.

Late at night, the old policeman on night duty in the adjoining room quietly opened the door. “Hey!” he called to me. “You must be cold. Come in here and get warm.”

Deliberately acting downcast, I shuffled into his room, sat in a chair and held out my hands to the charcoal brazier.

“You miss the dead girl, don’t you?”

“Yes.” I made my voice weak and faint.

“Of course you do. That’s human nature.” Gradually his tone became more assertive. “Where did you first have relations with her?” He made this inquiry with an air of authority that was worthy of a judge. He looked down on me as a child and seemed prepared to while away the long autumn night by acting as if he himself were in charge of the investigation, thereby getting me to confess to salacious details.

Quickly grasping his intent, it was all I could do to keep from laughing in his face. I knew I would be within my rights to refuse to cooperate with such an “off-book interrogation,” but the night ahead was long, and to liven it I assumed an outward air of utmost sincerity, as if I firmly believed that he was in charge of the investigation and could singlehandedly decide the severity of my penalty. I fabricated a statement to at least take the edge off his licentious curiosity.

“All right, that gives me a pretty good idea of how it went. When a prisoner answers questions honestly, we take that into consideration.”

“Thank you. I appreciate that very much.”

My performance was inspired, divine. A performance from which I derived no benefit whatsoever.

Sometime after dawn, the police chief sent for me; now the official interrogation would begin. When I opened the door and went into his office, he took one look at me and said, “Well, a handsome fellow! None of this is your fault. It’s your mother’s fault for giving birth to someone so devilishly handsome.”

The chief was still young, with a swarthy complexion and the air of a college educated man. Taken by surprise, I felt wretched and hideously disfigured, as though I had a red birthmark covering half my face.

The interrogation by this police chief, who had the build of a martial arts master, was cut and dried, a world away from the sly, thoroughly obscene midnight questioning of the old policeman. Afterward, as he filled out a form to send to the district attorney’s office, the chief remarked, “You’ve got to take better care of yourself. You’ve been coughing blood, haven’t you?”

That morning I had an oddly persistent cough, and every time I coughed I covered my mouth with a handkerchief that was spattered with blood. The spots were not from my throat, however. The night before, I had fiddled with a small pimple under my ear, and that was the source of the bleeding. It crossed my mind that I was better off not revealing this, so I merely looked down and said solemnly, “Yes, sir.”

The police chief finished writing. “Whether you’ll be indicted is for the prosecutor to decide, but you should go ahead and arrange by telegram or telephone to have someone come pick you up today at the public prosecutor’s office in Yokohama. There must be somebody you can ask, a guardian or a guarantor.”

I remembered that an antique dealer named Shibuta from my hometown, a frequent visitor at my father’s house in Tokyo, was my guarantor at

college. A bachelor in his forties, short and heavyset, he was always playing up to my father. His face, particularly the eyes, looked so much like a flatfish that Father always called him that, and I was used to calling him by his nickname, too.

I borrowed a telephone book, found Flatfish's home phone number, and gave him a call. When I asked him to come pick me up at the public prosecutor's office in Yokohama, he responded in a haughty tone completely unlike his usual ingratiating manner, but even so, he agreed to do it.

After I returned to the isolation room, the police chief barked out an order, his voice so loud that even I could hear: "Hey, hurry up and disinfect the phone, will you? The guy's coughing blood!"

That afternoon, my arms were bound to my torso with narrow hemp rope, and while I was permitted to conceal my bondage under a cloak, a young policeman kept a firm grip on the end of the rope as the two of us headed off to Yokohama by streetcar.

I felt not the least bit anxious. I looked back fondly on the isolation room and the old policeman. Why am I like this? Though I was tied up like a criminal, I felt relieved, and even now, as I set down my recollections of that day in a calm, reflective state of mind, I am enjoying myself, perfectly at ease.

But mixed in with my fond memories of that time is the haunting memory of a colossal failure. I underwent a simple interrogation in a dimly lit room in the public prosecutor's office. The prosecutor was a quiet man of around forty (whereas my good looks, if any, were undoubtedly tainted with sensuality, his were what I would call proper good looks, exuding an air of intelligent serenity), and his personality seemed so easygoing that I was making my statement absentmindedly, guard down. Then all at once that cough of mine came back, and I brought out my handkerchief. Seeing the bloodstains on it, the shameful thought struck me that perhaps my cough might again be of some use. I added a couple of fake coughs for good measure, exaggerating them for effect, and then, still holding the

handkerchief over my mouth, I glanced at the prosecutor's face.

"Was that real?" he asked with a quiet smile.

I broke into a cold sweat. Even now, looking back, I go into a dizzy panic. It was far worse than the time in middle school when that dummy Takeichi jabbed me in the back and said the words "on purpose," plunging me into hell. This notebook contains the record of the two times in my life when my act flopped. I think sometimes I'd rather have been handed a ten-year sentence than face the prosecutor's quiet contempt.

The indictment was suspended. I wasn't at all glad, but sat in utter wretchedness on a bench outside the prosecutor's office, waiting for Flatfish to come pick me up.

Through a high window I could see the sky at sunset, where a seagull was flying in the shape of the kanji character for "woman."

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Notebook Three:
Part One

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第三の手記 一

One of Takeichi's predictions came true and the other did not. His shameful prediction that women would fall for me proved accurate, but the pleasant one, his assurance that I would become a great painter, missed the mark.

I managed only to become a nameless hack who churned out manga for cheap magazines.

I was expelled from college because of the incident at Kamakura and went to live in a cubbyhole on the second floor of Flatfish's house. Once a month, a bit of money would arrive from home, coming not directly to me but secretly, by way of Flatfish. (I gathered that my brothers sent it, without

our father's knowledge.) Otherwise I was completely cut off from family. Flatfish was always in a bad humor, never returning my ingratiating smiles. The discovery that a human being could undergo a transformation with such apparent ease struck me as disgraceful—and, in equal or greater measure, comical.

"You mustn't go out. Whatever you do, please don't go out." That was all he ever said to me.

Flatfish seemed to have the idea that I might do myself in, that I was in danger of leaping into the sea after the woman, and that was why he gave me strict orders never to leave the house. Unable to drink or smoke, I stayed in my second-floor cubbyhole of a room reading old magazines from morning till night, living like a moron, drained of even the energy to commit suicide.

Flatfish's place was near the medical school in Okubo. The sign out front boasted "Garden of the Green Dragon: Fine Art and Antiques," but on the inside, the shop was narrow and dusty, its shelves lined with random, useless junk. (Not that Flatfish relied on the sale of that junk to make his living; he seemed rather to profit from facilitating the transfer of ownership of treasures from one gentleman client to another.) Flatfish was almost never physically present in the shop. Most mornings he hurried off somewhere with a scowl on his face, leaving a boy of seventeen or so to keep an eye on me. Anytime he had a spare moment, that boy would be out playing catch with neighborhood children. He seemed to regard me, the second-floor sponger, as an idiot or madman and would sometimes lecture me as if I were a child. Because I never can quarrel with anyone, I would adopt an air of weary admiration and listen submissively. Rumor had it that he was Flatfish's love child, whom for some complicated reason Flatfish could not openly acknowledge, and that this explained Flatfish's bachelorhood. I had previously heard these things whispered by members of my own family, but as I've never been able to work up much interest in others' life stories, I didn't know the details for certain. Still, something in the boy's eyes did suggest fish, so who knows, maybe he really was

Flatfish's son. In any case, they made a dismal pair. Sometimes late at night I heard them send out for noodles without telling me and eat in silence when the order came.

The boy made most of the meals. Three times a day, he carried a tray-table of food upstairs to me, the second-floor sponger. Flatfish and he rushed through their meals in a small, dank room at the foot of the stairs, amid a clattering of dishes.

One evening at the end of March, whether Flatfish had unexpectedly made a pile of money or conceived some plan, I don't know (even if both those suppositions were accurate, there could have been any number of other detailed reasons that I had no way of knowing), but he invited me downstairs to share a spread that for once included sake and, after he himself, the host, had expressed admiration and praise for the sashimi—not flatfish but tuna—he turned to me, the sponger sitting there in a daze, poured me a bit of sake and asked, "What do you intend to do after this, hmm?"

I didn't answer but picked up a sheet of dried sardines, looked into the silver eyes of the little fish and felt a wave of drunken nostalgia for the days when I used to go out and about in the city. I even felt nostalgia for Horiki. Such longing for freedom overtook me that I nearly gave in to tears.

Since going to live in that house, I had not had the strength for my usual clowning and simply lay around, the object of scornful looks from Flatfish and the boy. Flatfish seemed eager to avoid intimate talks and I, having no desire to run after him and make some sort of plea, had turned into this foolish parasite.

"A suspended indictment suggests that the incident won't remain on your record. So if you just set your mind to it, you can start a new life. If you are penitent and come to me with a serious proposal, I will give it my consideration."

The way he talked—or rather the way everyone in society talked—was convoluted and murky, so subtly intricate that it sounded weak; the tone of strict precaution, pointless as far as I could see, and the endless, fussy

haggling always left me so bewildered that I lost interest and either started clowning and making fun of the whole business or else gave silent assent, leaving everything to others in defeat.

If only Flatfish had spoken to me in the following simple way, that would have settled things, I later realized, feeling deep melancholy for his unwarranted cautiousness, or rather for society's enigmatic pretension and concern for appearances. All he had to say was, "Starting in April, enroll in school somewhere, either a national university or a private one. Once you do that, your folks will increase your allowance to cover your living expenses."

As I found out much later, this actual plan had been decided on. I would certainly have gone along with the idea. Flatfish's roundabout, overly cautious way of speaking completely messed things up and forever changed the course of my life.

"If you aren't willing to come to me with a serious proposal, then my hands are tied."

"What kind of proposal?" I truly had no idea.

"That's something you must ask yourself, don't you think?"

"Like what?"

"Like what do you intend to do with yourself from now on?"

"Should I get a job?"

"The question is, how do *you* feel about it?"

"Well, the trouble with going to school is…"

"It costs money. But money isn't the real problem. The problem is knowing what you want."

Why didn't he just come out with it and say, "Your folks have agreed to pay for you to go back to school"? Knowing that would have settled my concerns. Instead, I was in a deep fog.

"How about it? Do you have some sort of hope for your future? I tell you, taking on responsibility for another person is harder than that person can possibly understand."

"I'm sorry."

“It’s a true source of worry. But I have taken on full responsibility for you, and I don’t want to see you avoid commitment. I want you to show me that you’re determined to make something of yourself. Come to me with a serious proposal, and I am prepared to respond. Of course, a poor man like me can only do so much. If you’re expecting to live in luxury the way you used to, you’ve got another think coming. But if you pull yourself together, work out a clear plan for your future and bring it to me, I am prepared to offer what little aid I can, bit by bit, for the sake of your new life. Now do you understand what I’m saying? So tell me: what exactly do you plan to do next?”

“If I can’t stay here, then I’ll get a job and—”

“Are you serious? Nowadays, not even graduates of Tokyo Imperial University—”

“I’m not saying I’d get an office job.”

“What, then?”

“I’ll be a painter,” I said boldly.

“Whaat?”

I will never forget the sly shadow that crossed Flatfish’s face as he ducked his head and laughed, a shadow suggestive of scorn, yet somehow different. To compare society to the ocean, it was the weird sort of shadow you would expect to find adrift in the ocean’s bottomless depths, a laugh that afforded a glimpse into the inmost recesses of adult life.

That’s out of the question, you haven’t pulled yourself together in the slightest, think it over, see that you give the matter some serious thought tonight: with these words at my back, I fled upstairs as if I were being chased, but even after I went to bed, nothing came to mind. Then dawn came, and I ran away from Flatfish’s house.

I’ll be back this evening for sure. I’m going to see the friend named below to talk over my future plans, so don’t worry. I mean it.

I wrote this on notepaper in pencil, jotted down Horiki’s name and

address—“*Masao Horiki, Asakusa*”—and sneaked out of the house.

I didn’t run away in a fit of pique at Flatfish’s lecture. He was absolutely right. I couldn’t pull myself together, I had no notion what I might do in the future, and I couldn’t just go on imposing on him. Even if I somehow managed to rouse myself to find a worthy goal, how could I possibly finance a new life with monthly assistance from someone as poor as him? I recoiled at the idea. I left because I couldn’t bear to stay a moment longer.

But I certainly had no serious intent to talk over my “future plans” with the likes of Horiki. I left the note because I wanted to set Flatfish’s mind at ease for a short time, even momentarily. (Rather than writing the note as a detective-story ploy to buy time for my getaway—though that thought was faintly in the back of my mind—it’s more accurate to say I wrote it out of fear that the shock of my disappearance would greatly upset Flatfish. Though the truth inevitably comes out, my fear of stating the plain facts gives me an unfortunate tendency to embellish. Many people would therefore scorn me as a liar, but my embellishments are almost never self-serving. It’s just that I have a suffocating dread of sudden changes, the sort that spoil the atmosphere. I am so desperate to please that more often than not I add a word of embellishment, however warped, feeble or stupid it may be, and even knowing that doing so will work against me in the long run. And this is a habit of mine that society’s “honest souls” have taken full advantage of.) And so on the spur of the moment I dredged up Horiki’s full name and address and scribbled them on the bottom of the page.

I left Flatfish’s house and walked to Shinjuku, where I sold some books I had brought along. After that I had no idea what to do.

Though I am always sociable, I have never once known true friendship. Apart from Horiki, who kept me company in my wanderings about town, all my associations have only caused me distress. To relieve that distress, I would throw my energies into clowning and become so exhausted that merely catching sight of a distant acquaintance on the street or someone who looked like someone I knew was a nasty surprise that made me momentarily dizzy and gave me chills. I knew what it was to be liked, but I

seemed to be deficient in the ability to love. (Then again, I have grave doubts about the ability of any human being to love.) As a result, I could never have anything remotely like a buddy. I even lacked the ability to call on anyone. The gate to any house was more daunting to me than the *Divine Comedy's* Gate of Hell. I had the actual, vivid sensation that behind the gate lurked a horrible monster like a dragon, writhing and emitting a foul odor.

I had no friends. Nowhere to go.

Horiki.

This was one of those times when a word spoken in jest turns out to be true. I'd scribbled his name at random on the note I left behind, but now I decided I would, in fact, go call on him in Asakusa. Never before had I taken it upon myself to visit Horiki at home; mostly I summoned him to my place by telegram. Now even the cost of a telegram was problematic, and anyway, disgrace had so damaged my ego that I feared if I were to send him a telegram, he might not come. I made up my mind to go see him, even though paying calls was the hardest thing in the world for me. I boarded the streetcar with a sigh. The realization that my sole lifeline was of all people Horiki overwhelmed me and sent a chill down my spine.

Horiki was home. He lived in a two-story house down a squalid alley. He occupied the lone, medium-sized room on the second floor, while downstairs, his elderly parents and a young workman stitched cloth strips and pounded them to make thongs for *geta* clogs.

That day, Horiki showed me a new aspect of himself as a city dweller, by which I mean utter nerve, an egoism so cold and calculating that a country boy like me could only stare in wide-eyed amazement. He wasn't perpetually passive and compliant, like me.

"I can't believe what you pulled off. Has your old man forgiven you yet? No?"

I couldn't tell him I'd run away. As usual, I was evasive, even though he was bound to hit on the truth before long. "Things'll work out in the end."

"Come on, this is no laughing matter. Take my advice and quit acting like an idiot, will you? I've got business to take care of today. I've got a lot

going on.”

“Business? What business?”

“Hey! Don’t pull the thread off the cushion!”

While we talked, without realizing it I’d been toying with a tassel thread on a corner of the cushion I was sitting on—binding thread, I think it’s called. Horiki evidently felt so proudly possessive of everything in his house, down to a strand of thread on a cushion, that he scolded me angrily without the slightest sign of embarrassment. I realized that his association with me had never cost him anything.

His mother brought up a tray with two bowls of *shiruko*, sweet bean soup over sticky mochi.

“Well, isn’t this nice!” Horiki expressed profound, apparently sincere appreciation, the very model of a grateful son. With what struck me as unnatural politeness, he went on, “Thank you so much, Mother. You made shiruko? That’s really great. You shouldn’t have gone to so much trouble. I’m just about to leave, but I can’t go off without some of your wonderful shiruko! I’ll dig in.” He turned to me. “Have some. She went to all the trouble of making it for us. Oh, man, this is good. Really great.”

He ate with a joy and gusto that didn’t seem put on for show. I sipped my shiruko, but it was watery, and the mochi tasted like something else, a substance impossible to identify. I did not despise their poverty. (At the time, I didn’t think the shiruko tasted bad, and the old woman’s thoughtfulness was genuinely touching. Poverty inspires fear in me but not contempt.) The shiruko, and Horiki’s joy in it, were an object lesson in city-dwellers’ true frugality and the careful distinction that Tokyoites maintain between their lives at home and away. I had the dismaying feeling that I alone was a dimwit whose private and public lives were undifferentiated, someone forever fleeing the society of human beings, abandoned even by Horiki. I sat plying worn lacquer chopsticks as I ate the shiruko and felt, I will note here, exceedingly forlorn.

“Sorry, but I have to go.” Horiki stood up and put on his jacket. “I’m off. Sorry.”

Then a woman caller appeared, and my life changed.

Horiki was suddenly energized. “Oh, hey. I was just about to head off to see you when this fellow showed up. No, it’s fine. Come on in.”

He acted awfully flustered. I took the cushion from under me, flipped it over and held it out, and he snatched it out of my hand and flipped it over again before offering it to her. In the whole room, besides the one Horiki was sitting on, there was only one extra cushion for company.

The woman was tall and thin. She sat down in a corner near the door, giving the cushion a pass.

I listened idly to their conversation. I gathered that she worked for a magazine and had come to collect an illustration that she had previously asked Horiki to do.

“We need it quickly.”

“It’s ready. I finished it quite some time ago. Here, take a look.”

A telegram arrived.

As Horiki read it, his sunny expression turned to a look of disgust. “Dammit! What have you done?”

The telegram was from Flatfish.

“Go back there right now. I should take you myself, but I just don’t have the time. You look awfully carefree for someone who just ran away from home.”

“Where do you live?” the woman asked.

“In Okubo,” I said automatically, before I had time to think.

“That’s near my company.”

She had moved to Tokyo from the city of Koshu and was twenty-eight years old. She lived in Koenji with her five-year-old daughter. She had been a widow for three years.

“You seem like someone who had a hard time growing up. You’re sweet. Poor dear.”

For the first time in my life, I lived as a kept man. After Shizuko (that was the magazine reporter’s name) left in the morning to work at the publishing house in nearby Shinjuku, I stayed home with her daughter, Shigeko. Until I

moved in, while her mother was out Shigeko would go to the apartment manager's room to play, but she seemed delighted to have acquired a "sweet" man for a playmate.

I stayed there aimlessly for a week or so. Caught in electric wires just outside the window was a kite shaped like a man in kimono with arms spread wide. Buffeted and torn by the dusty winds of spring, the man-kite hung on grimly, twisting in the wires, seeming at times to nod. Every time I saw the thing, I smiled sheepishly and blushed. It haunted my dreams.

"I wish I had some money," I said.

A pause. "How much?"

"A lot. It's true what they say, you know: when poverty comes in at the door, love flies out at the window."

"Don't be silly. That's so trite."

"Is it? But you never know. If things go on this way, I might run away."

"Which one of us is poor? And which one is going to run away? Talk sense."

"I want to buy alcohol, no, cigarettes, with money I earn. I'm a better artist than Horiki any day."

I had in mind the self-portraits I'd drawn back in middle school, the ones Takeichi had called "monsters." My lost masterpieces. In the course of many moves, they had disappeared. I felt they had truly been fine works of art. Since then I had tried many times to paint but never produced anything the least bit close to those memorable gems. I suffered from a listless sense of loss, as if my heart were hollow.

An unfinished glass of absinthe.

In my mind, that was how I described that sense of irreparable loss. When the topic of painting came up, that unfinished glass of absinthe would flicker before me, tormenting me with the impatient longing to show her those paintings and convince her of my artistic ability.

She was amused. "Are you? It's adorable, the way you joke with a straight face."

It's not a joke, it's true. If I could only show her those paintings . . . This

anguished thought would go around and around in my head until, changing my mind, I gave up. “Better at manga, I mean. When it comes to manga, I’ve got Horiki beat.”

More than desperate appeals, she took seriously such clownish dissembling.

“You know, actually, I’ve been admiring your manga. The ones you draw for Shigeko make me laugh out loud. Why not go ahead and give it a try? I can put in a word with the chief editor at our company if you like.”

Her company published a monthly magazine for children, one that had yet to make much of a name for itself.

“Women just take one look at you and immediately they are beside themselves, wanting to do something for you.” “You’re timid, and yet you’re funny.” “Sometimes you sit alone, brooding, but that only makes a woman’s heart yearn to help you all the more.”

Shizuko said many such things, meaning to flatter me, but I knew that these were the disgusting attributes of a kept man and so I continued to brood. Unable to cheer up, wanting money more than a woman, I secretly longed to get away and earn my own living. My schemes backfired, however, making me increasingly dependent on her. In her strong-minded way, she dealt with the messy aftermath of my running away from Flatfish’s place, as well as other things, and as a result I became even more timid around her.

At Shizuko’s instigation, Flatfish, Horiki and she got together and settled on a plan: I would end relations with my family, and she and I would live together as man and wife. Thanks to her efforts on my behalf, my manga sold surprisingly well. I used the income to buy alcohol and cigarettes, but my loneliness and gloom only deepened. I did nothing but brood, so homesick and despondent that often as I was drawing “The Adventures of Kinta and Ota,” the monthly manga series for Shizuko’s magazine, my pen would stop moving and I would bend my head in tears.

At such times I felt a slight salvation in little Shigeko, who by then was freely calling me “Daddy.”

“Daddy, is it true that God will give you anything you pray for?”

I more than anyone wanted to pray in supplication: *Grant me an icy will. Grant me understanding of what it is to be human. Is it not a sin to push others aside? Grant me a mask of anger*.

“That’s right, Shige-chan. I’m sure He’ll give *you* anything, but maybe not me.”

I was afraid even of God, unable to believe in divine love, able only to believe in divine punishment. Faith. To me, that meant simply facing God’s judgment seat with head bowed, prepared to accept his chastisement. I could believe in hell, but not in the existence of heaven.

“Why not you, Daddy?”

“Because I disobeyed my father.”

“You did? But everybody says you’re nice.”

That’s because I had them all fooled. Everyone in the building felt friendly toward me, I knew that, but how could I possibly convey to Shigeko how afraid of them all I was, and how the more afraid I was, the more they liked me, and the more they liked me the more I feared them and had to distance myself from them? This unhappy sickness of mine was beyond explanation. Casually, I changed the subject.

“Shige-chan, what do you want to ask God for?”

“I want my real Daddy back.”

Shock made me dizzy. Enemies. Whether I was her enemy or she was mine, now somewhere there was another grown-up who posed a threat to me. The face of a stranger, an inscrutable stranger, a stranger full of secrets: all at once that’s how Shigeko’s face looked to me.

Shigeko alone was different, I had thought, but all along she, too, had possessed a cow’s tail, capable of lashing out and killing a fly. After that, I was timid even around her.

“Lover boy! You home?”

Horiki began coming to see me again. Even after the loneliness he’d inflicted on me the day I ran away, I still couldn’t refuse to see him and greeted him with a dim smile.

“Your manga are pretty popular, I hear. Well, an amateur knows no fear—foolhardy courage is hard to beat. Watch yourself, though. Your drawings aren’t quite up to snuff.”

He had the nerve to talk down to me, as if he were the master. *If only I could show him my “monster” paintings*, I thought, still suffering from that endlessly recurring fantasy. *I’d like to see the look on his face then*.

“Don’t say that! Makes me want to scream.”

Horiki looked more pleased with himself than ever. “Just remember, a knack for getting on in the world will only take you so far. Eventually you’ll betray yourself.”

A knack for getting on in the world? Me? I rolled my eyes. Then again, perhaps in fearing, avoiding, and deceiving others, I was actually in line with the sort of shrewd, world-weary approach to life that is embodied in the proverb “Let sleeping dogs lie.” People don’t know each other at all, really. It’s possible to have a completely mistaken view of someone, consider him your best friend, and even, when he dies, deliver a tearful eulogy, all without ever having known who he truly was.

Having participated (no doubt reluctantly, at Shizuko’s urging) in discussions to settle the aftermath of my running away, Horiki began acting as if he were a great benefactor of mine, responsible for my rehabilitation, or else my go-between. He would lecture me with a straight face. He often dropped by late, drunk, and stayed the night or borrowed five yen (it was always five yen) before going on his way.

“But seriously, no more fooling around with women. Society is unforgiving.”

What does “society” mean, anyhow? The collective plural of “human being”? What is the substance of society? All my life, I had thought of society as something strong, harsh and intimidating, but when Horiki said that, the words “Society is you, isn’t it?” were on the tip of my tongue, although, not wanting to anger him, I bit them back.

Society is unforgiving.

—It’s not society that’s unforgiving, it’s you, isn’t it?

Do that, and society will give you a hard time.

—Not society. You will.

Society will ostracize you.

—No, not society. You will do the ostracizing, won't you?

Know thyself—thy horror, grotesquerie, villainy, cunning, sorcery! Many more such words flashed through my mind, but all I did was wipe my face with a handkerchief and laugh. "You've got me in a cold sweat!"

From that time on, I have operated under the guiding principle that society is the individual.

Ever since I began to suspect that society is the individual, I had become slightly more able to act of my own volition. In Shizuko's words, I'd gotten "a bit willful and not so timid." To Horiki, I'd become "weirdly stingy." And as Shigeko put it, I'd "stopped being nice to Shigeko."

Taciturn and unsmiling, day after day, while babysitting I would work on "The Adventures of Kinta and Ota," "The Easygoing Priest"—a clear rip-off of "Easygoing Daddy"—or "Harum-Scarum Pin-chan," a manga serial whose title made no sense even to me, something I came up with in desperation. I worked sluggishly in a truly dismal state of mind, filling orders from various publishing companies (little by little, orders had started trickling in from other companies besides Shizuko's, but always from vulgar, third-rate publishers), wanting only to earn enough to buy alcohol. When Shizuko came home from work, I would switch places with her, popping off to a street stall or bar near Koenji Station to down cheap, strong drinks, and then return to the apartment feeling slightly cheered.

"The more I look at you, the funnier your face looks to me," I'd say to Shigeko. "You know, the idea for the Easygoing Priest's face came to me from looking at you when you're asleep."

"When you're sleeping, you look like an old man, a man in his forties."

"That's your fault. You've sucked me dry. *The flow of the water and hu-u-man life. Why so mournful, riverside wi-i-llow?*"

"Don't make so much noise. Hurry and get ready for bed. Or would you like something to eat?" She said this with utter calm, not rising to my bait.

“I’ll have a nightcap.” I burst into drunken song again. “*The flow of the water and hu-u-man life. The flow of human* . . . no, I mean *the flow of the water and wa-a-ter life*.”

While I sang, Shizuko would undress me, and I would fall asleep with my forehead pressed against her breast. This was our nightly routine.

The next day you do the same things over again,
Following the same rule as the day before:
That is, by avoiding great, savage joy
You avoid great sorrow as well,
The way a toad goes around a stone in its path.

When I came across this verse by Guy-Charles Cros, translated into Japanese by Bin Ueda, my face turned a fiery red.

A toad.

(That was me. It wasn’t a question of society being forgiving or unforgiving, ostracizing me or not. I was an animal lower than a dog, lower than a cat. A toad. All I did was shamble along.)

Gradually, I was drinking more. I went out to drink not just by Koenji Station, but also in Shinjuku and even on the Ginza strip. Sometimes I stayed out all night and, to avoid following any “rule,” acted like a hooligan in bars, kissing all the girls and in general reverting to the wild, dissipated life I had led before the suicide pact—or worse. When I ran short of money I even resorted to pawning Shizuko’s clothes.

One day—this was more than a year after the time in late spring when I’d moved in with Shizuko and smiled wryly at the torn man-kite—I again took one of her obi sashes, an under-kimono and a few other things, pawned the lot, and went on a drinking spree on the Ginza. I stayed away two nights in succession. On the third evening, I went home feeling guilty and sneaked up to the door of the apartment. From inside I could hear mother and daughter talking.

“Why does he drink?”

“Daddy doesn’t drink because he likes it. He drinks because he’s such a good person, that’s why.”

“Do good people drink a lot?”

“No, not really.”

“Daddy will be surprised, won’t he?”

“He might not like it. See there, it’s jumped out of its box!”

“Just like Harum-Scarum Pin-chan!”

“That’s right!” Shizuko said with a low laugh, sounding heartily amused.

I opened the door a crack and peered inside. Hopping around the room was a white baby rabbit, with the two of them in pursuit.

(*They’re happy, these two. If a jerk like me joins them, I’ll only mess things up. Modest happiness. A nice mother and daughter. Let them be happy. Dear God, if you hear the prayers of someone like me, just this once, hear my prayer*.)

I felt like kneeling and folding my hands. Softly I closed the door, went back to the Ginza, and never lived in that apartment again.

After that I crashed on the second floor of a bar near Kyobashi and became a kept man once more.

Society. I felt I was beginning to get a handle on the concept. It meant conflict between individuals, extemporaneous conflict, conflict demanding on-the-spot victory. *Human beings never submit to other human beings*. Even slaves engage in mean, servile retaliation. Survival depends on extemporaneous matches of the winner-takes-all variety. Though people mouth allegiance to higher principles, the focus of their efforts is always an individual. Behind the individual is another individual. The abstruseness of society is the abstruseness of the individual. Society is not an ocean, but the individual: this discovery freed me somewhat from the terrifying specter of society as an ocean and, no longer engaging in endless, random acts of consideration, I became able to display a certain gall as the moment required.

When I left the Koenji apartment, “I just broke up with her” was all I said to the madam of the bar in Kyobashi, and that was enough. Victory in the

winner-takes-all match was mine. That very night, I moved rashly into that living area over the bar, but society, for all its supposed terrors, did me no harm. Nor did I justify myself to society in any way. If it was okay with the madam, that was all I needed to know.

I was like a client, but I was like a husband, too, or an errand boy or some kind of relative. Despite my assuredly enigmatic status, “society” never lifted an eyebrow but treated me with the utmost cordiality, calling me familiarly by name and even pouring me drinks.

Gradually I stopped being wary. I began to think that society was not so scary after all. In my fear, I had resembled those who tremble at “scientific superstitions” warning that spring breezes are full of whooping cough germs; that germs in the public bath cause blindness, germs at the barbershop cause baldness, and train straps are crawling with mites; that sashimi and rare or undercooked meat inevitably contain tapeworm larvae, flukes and all manner of parasite eggs; and that if you walk barefoot, a tiny glass shard will enter through the sole of your foot, circulate through your body to your eye and make you go blind. Certainly, the existence of swarms of wriggling germs is scientifically accurate. But at the same time, I began to understand that if I ignored them, they would become mere “scientific ghosts” and disappear in a flash, having nothing to do with me.

“Scientific statistics” had terrorized me. Ten million people all leaving three rice grains uneaten in their lunchboxes every day would mean the waste of dozens of bales of rice. If ten million people all cut down their daily use of tissue paper by a single sheet, vast amounts of wood pulp could be saved. Every time I left a single grain of rice uneaten, every time I blew my nose, I suffered from the illusion that I was wasting a mountain of rice or wood pulp and felt as glum as if I had committed a grave offense.

But those were in fact scientific, statistical, mathematical lies. The leftover grains of rice could never be collected. Even as math word problems, the topics were primitive and moronic, as absurd as calculating the probability of someone losing their balance in a dark toilet and falling in, or getting a foot caught between the train car and the platform. Such

mishaps sound plausible, but you never actually hear of anyone getting injured by failing to straddle the toilet properly. Gradually I'd come to understand the substance of society to the extent that I could look back with affection and laughter on myself, Yozo Oba, who, having had that hypothetical situation drummed into him as "scientific fact," had until the day before accepted the danger as real and lived in terror of it.

Despite this progress, I still had a dread of human beings. Before meeting customers in the bar, I had to down a big swig of sake. Curiosity often got the better of my fears, drawing me into the bar every night. Like a child who clutches all the tighter a small animal he is rather afraid of, I would harangue customers with drunken rants on the theory of art.

I was a manga artist, a nameless cartoonist who knew neither great joy nor great sorrow. However much later great sorrow might come to me, however much I secretly longed for great, savage joy, my only pleasures of the moment were trading useless comments with customers and drinking their sake.

Soon it was nearly a year since I had taken up this wasteful life in Kyobashi. My manga were running not only in children's magazines but in tawdry, obscene magazines sold in stations. Under the crazy pen name Sir Faifa Drowning (survived a drowning) I penned dirty nude drawings accompanied by verses from "The Rubaiyat."

Quit praying useless prayers, will you?
Be done with everything sentimental—
Come, have a drink! Remember only the good times.
Who needs solicitude? Let it go.

Those who threaten others with terror and unease
Cower at their own egregious sins
Concocting scheme after scheme
To fend off the revenge of the dead.

Last night, full of wine, my heart rejoiced;
This morning, sober, all is bleak.
I can only marvel at how my mood
Changes so completely overnight.

Don’t fret about divine retribution,
A prospect as disturbing as
The echo of a distant drum.
If we must pay for every fart, there is no hope.

Is justice the guiding principle in life?
What justice lies, pray tell,
On a bloody battlefield
Or at the tip of the assassin’s sword?

Wherein lies life’s guiding principle?
What light of wisdom may there be?
This fleeting life is at once beautiful and terrifying:
Frail, we are saddled with burdens too heavy to bear.

All because we are implanted with seeds of uncontrollable desire,
We are plagued with talk of right and wrong, crime and punishment.
Helpless, we are in a constant muddle,
Granted neither the power nor the will to overcome.

Where have I been wandering, lost?
Criticizing, examining, reconsidering what?
Ah—chasing empty dreams, unreal phantasmagoria.
Aha! Forgot my wine. All this is but the musings of a fool.

Listen to me. Look up at the vastness of the sky.
We are tiny specks in the universe, no more.

Who can say what keeps this planet spinning?
Earth does as it pleases—rotate, revolve, turn upside down.

Sensing supreme Power everywhere,
Discovering in all peoples of every land
A common humanity,
I am called a heretic.

Everyone reads scripture wrong.
Or else there is no common sense, no wisdom.
Forbidding the pleasures of the flesh, giving up wine . . .
Sheesh. Mustafa, I despise such things!

But around that time, a certain young miss was urging me to give up drinking. She was a girl of seventeen or eighteen named Yoshi who worked in the little cigarette stand across the street from the bar. She had fair skin and a charming double tooth. Every time I stopped by to purchase cigarettes, she would smile and chide me:

"You're terrible, always drunk in the middle of the day."

"What's so terrible about it? Why not be drunk? 'Quaff wine to the very last drop, my child; away with enmity, away!' said an ancient Persian. 'Let us leave off. Hope for the grief-weary heart lies only in the intoxicating cup.' Get it?"

"No."

"You little dickens. I'm going to kiss you."

"Go right ahead." Unfazed, she pursed her lips.

"Don't be silly. Have you no shame?"

But the look on Yoshi's face clearly marked her as an untouched virgin.

One bitterly cold January night, I set out to buy cigarettes, drunk as usual, and fell in the manhole in front of the cigarette stand. When I called out to Yoshi for help she pulled me out, tended to the injury on my right arm, and

said quietly and soberly, “You drink too much.”

I’m the sort of person who’s unafraid of dying but can’t bear the thought of hurting myself, bleeding, and becoming disabled, so while she tended to my arm I decided to give up drinking.

“I’ll quit. From tomorrow, I won’t drink a drop.”

“Really?”

“I mean it. I’ll quit. Then will you marry me?” The bit about marrying me was a joke.

“Natch.”

“Natch” was short for “naturally.” All sorts of abbreviated words were trending then, including *mobo* for “modern boy” and *moga* for “modern girl.”

“All right, let’s make a pinky promise. I’ll quit for sure.”

The next day, I started drinking in the daytime again. In the evening, I staggered over to Yoshi’s stand and stood swaying in front of it

“Sorry, Yoshi. I’m drunk again.”

“You’re mean, pretending to be drunk like that.”

Startled, I began to sober up. “No, it’s true. I really am drunk. I’m not pretending.”

“Don’t tease me. Be nice.” She never doubted me for a minute.

“Surely you can tell by looking. I’ve been drinking since noon. Forgive me.”

“You certainly put on a good act.”

“It’s not an act, you idiot. I’m going to kiss you.”

“Go ahead.”

“No, I don’t deserve to. Can’t marry you, either. Look at my face. See how red it is? I’m sloshed.”

“It’s red from the rays of the setting sun. I’m not falling for your little joke. Yesterday you promised to quit. There’s no way you’d be drunk today. You made a pinky promise. How can you say you’ve been drinking? It’s a lie, a whopping lie!”

I looked at Yoshi seated inside the cigarette stand, at her smiling, cream-

colored face amid the shadows. *Ah, how precious is such unsullied virginity. I've never slept with a virgin younger than me. I'll marry her. However great a sorrow lies in store for us, I don't care. For once in my life, I want to experience great, savage joy. I always thought virginal beauty was the indulgent, sentimental fantasy of silly poets, but it's real, it exists. I'll marry her, and in the spring when the new leaves come out we'll bike over to see a waterfall*. I made up my mind on the spot; seizing that once-in-a-lifetime chance, I did not hesitate to steal her flower.

In time we married, and while the joy we obtained was not so very great, the subsequent sorrow was beyond horrifying, unimaginably huge. Society was after all deeply terrifying to me. Seizing this opportunity wasn't enough to settle my life. Society was far harsher than that.

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Notebook Three: Part Two

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第三の手記

Horiki and me.

Despite our mutual contempt, we kept on seeing each other. If what the world calls friendship consists in dragging each other down, then Horiki and I were definitely friends.

Through the chivalry of the madam of the Kyobashi bar (using the word “chivalry” in reference to a woman is unconventional, but in my experience, city women are far more chivalrous than city men, who are generally timid, obsessed with appearances and stingy besides), I was able to marry Yoshiko. We set up housekeeping in a rented room on the ground

floor of a wooden apartment building in Tsukiji, near the Sumida River. I quit drinking and devoted myself to drawing the manga that were becoming my steady profession. After dinner, we would go see a movie and stop in a coffee shop on the way home or buy a potted flower. More than anything, I loved listening to my little bride, who trusted me with all her heart, and watching her movements. My heart begin to warm with the faint hope that I might in time become somewhat human and avoid having to die a tragic death. And then along came Horiki.

“Hey there, lover boy! Wait, what’s this? I’ll be damned. You look like a solid citizen for once. The lady in Koenji sent me.” He lowered his voice and jerked his chin toward Yoshiko, who was in the kitchen making tea. “Okay if I go on?”

“Absolutely. You can say anything in front of her.” I was calm.

Yoshiko had a genius for trusting me, and not just about my relations with the madam of the Kyobashi bar; even when I told her what had happened in Kamakura, she never suspected me of having loved Tsuneko, and not because I was a skillful liar. Sometimes I described the incident in plain terms, but to Yoshiko it all sounded like a joke.

“Cocky as ever, aren’t we!” Horiki said. “Well, it’s nothing big. She wants you to drop by and say hello now and then.”

Just when you begin to forget, an ominous bird comes flying up and pecks at the wounds of memory. Instantly, past scenes of shame and guilt unfolded before me with such vividness that I wanted to scream in terror. I couldn’t sit still.

Me: “Want to go drinking?”

Horiki: “Sure.”

Horiki and me. We resembled each other. Sometimes I even thought we were identical, but that of course was only when we were making the rounds of bars, drinking cheap liquor. In any case, when the two of us got together, we changed into a pair of dogs of the same shape and coat, roaming the snowy streets of Tokyo.

From that day on, we renewed our old friendship and went back together

to the little bar in Kyobashi, among other places. Eventually we even showed up at Shizuko's apartment in Koenji, a pair of drunken dogs, and spent the night.

I will never forget: one sultry summer evening, just as the sun was setting, Horiki came to my place in Tsukiji wearing a worn-out cotton kimono. He'd pawned his summer clothes that day because he needed cash, but if his aged mother found out it would be awkward; he wanted to redeem the pawned items right away, so would I lend him some money? Unfortunately I, too, was broke. As usual, I instructed Yoshiko to take some of her clothes to a pawnshop and convert them to cash. After Horiki got his loan, there was a bit left over, so I had her go out and spend the remainder on distilled spirits. We went up on the rooftop to drink as we took in the occasional breeze off the Sumida River, redolent of drainage ditches: a truly grubby version of the elegant summer pastime.

We started a guessing game involving comic nouns and tragic nouns. It was a game I invented. Nouns come in categories of masculine, feminine and neuter, but there ought to be a distinction between comic and tragic nouns. "Steamboat" and "train," for example, are tragic, while "streetcar" and "bus" are comic. Anyone who doesn't understand why is unqualified to speak of art. A playwright who inserts even one tragic noun into a comedy is a failure, and the same goes for inserting comic nouns into a tragedy.

"Ready? How about 'cigarette'?"

"Tragic," Horiki said promptly.

"And 'medicine'?"

"Powder or pills?"

"Injection."

"Tragic."

"You think so? There are hormone injections, too, you know."

"Definitely tragic. Needles are involved, and there's nothing more tragic than a needle."

"Okay, I'll let you have that one. But medicine and doctors are surprisingly comic. How about death?"

“Comic. Also Christian pastors and Buddhist priests.”

“Very good! And life is tragic.”

“Nope. That’s comic, too.”

“Then everything is! Here’s one more for you. What about manga artist? Surely that’s not a comic noun?”

“Tragic. An enormously tragic noun.”

“What do you mean? An enormous tragedy would be you, not me.”

Any game that sinks to the level of such stupid jokes is dopey, but we took great pride in these exchanges, convinced we were displaying a degree of wit unknown in the world’s salons.

I also invented another, similar game, a guessing game of antonyms. The antonym of black is white. The antonym of white, however, is red, and that of red is black.

“What’s the opposite of flower?” I asked.

Horiki twisted his mouth, considering. “Well, there used to be a restaurant called ‘Flower Moon,’ so, moon.”

“That’s not an antonym. It’s more of a synonym, the way stars are synonymous with violets. An antonym it’s not.”

“I’ve got it. Bee.”

“Bee?”

“Peonies are crawling with . . . oh wait, it’s ants.”

“Yikes, that’s no antonym, it’s a motif. You’re slipping.”

“I’ve got it! Clouds.”

“Clouds hide the moon, though.”

“Right, right. Wind scatters blossoms. The antonym of flower is wind.”

“Not great. Sounds like a line from a popular ditty. You’re betraying your roots.”

“All right then, how about the lute?”

“Worse and worse. The antonym of flower has to be . . . you have to name the least flowerlike thing in the world.”

“Okay, so it’s . . . wait a minute. Oh, I know. Woman.”

“While you’re at it, why don’t you give me a synonym for woman.”

“Entrails.”

“You, sir, lack the heart of a poet. What’s the antonym of entrails?”

“Milk.”

“Not bad. Keep it up. Shame. What’s the antonym of shame?”

“Shameless. Like that hot manga artist, Sir Faifa Drowning,” he said.

“What about Masao Horiki?”

At this point neither of us was capable of laughing. We had succumbed to the gloom, the sensation that one’s head is full of broken glass, that comes from getting drunk on cheap spirits.

“Don’t get smart. At least I’ve never been tied up like a common criminal, unlike present company.”

I was shocked. So deep down, Horiki had never considered me reformed or respectable, had seen me only as a failed suicide without shame, a stupid ghost, a walking corpse. I was someone he could use as needed to supply his own amusement: that’s as far as his “friendship” went. This realization was of course unpleasant, but I soon backtracked. For him to take that view struck me as reasonable. From childhood, I’d never felt I deserved to be called human, after all. Maybe it was only right that even Horiki should hold me in contempt.

“Crime,” I said, affecting nonchalance. “What would the antonym of crime be? There’s a toughie.”

“Law,” Horiki replied with smooth equanimity.

I looked at his face. Red neon light from a sign on a nearby building flashing across his features gave him the stern authority of a relentless cop. Dumbfounded, I blurted, “Come on! That’s not even close.”

Imagine thinking the antonym of crime is law! But maybe that’s how most people in society get by, putting things in neat little categories, figuring that any place without cops is a hotbed of crime.

“What then—God? You have an annoying way of sounding like a damned preacher, you know that?”

“Hang on a minute. Let’s give it some more thought. Interesting topic, isn’t it? The way someone answered this question would tell you all you

needed to know about them, I bet."

"Nah. Look, the opposite of crime is virtue. Being a virtuous citizen. Someone like me, in other words."

"Ha. Joking aside, virtue's the opposite of vice, not of crime."

"Are vice and crime different?"

"I'd say so. Virtue and vice are man-made concepts, words applied to morality that people arbitrarily made up."

"Dammit. Now we're back at God. God, God. Leave it at God and be done with it. I'm hungry."

"Yoshiko's boiling beans downstairs."

"Good. I like beans." He plopped down flat on his back, hands behind his head.

"You don't seem interested in crime anyway."

"I'm not. I'm not a criminal like you. I may play around, but I don't make women die, and I don't wangle money from them."

I didn't make her die and I didn't wangle money from anyone, said a faint yet desperate voice inside me, but by force of habit I quickly reversed course and decided it was all my fault.

I lack the ability to argue with someone straight on. Thanks to the drunken gloom enveloping me, I was growing more irritated by the second, but I suppressed my anger and muttered half to myself:

"Crimes you go to jail for aren't the whole story. Maybe finding the antonym of crime would shed light on the true nature of crime. God . . . salvation . . . love . . . light . . . God has his opposite in Satan, and the opposite of salvation has to be suffering. The counterpart of love is hate, of light, darkness. Right and wrong, crime and prayer, crime and repentance, crime and confession, crime and . . . aagh, they're all synonymous! What's the antonym of crime?"

"Try sounding it out backwards, just the consonants. M-R-C . . . murk? Pork'd be better. I'm so hungry. Bring me something to eat."

"Go get it yourself, why don't you!" My voice trembled with a rage I had seldom known.

“All right then, I’ll pop on downstairs, and Yoshi-chan and I’ll commit a crime together. A direct investigation’s better than all this debating. The antonym of crime is pork and beans—no, fava beans!” His speech was badly slurred.

“Suit yourself. Just go away.”

“Crime and hunger, hunger and fava beans. Bah, they’re all synonyms.” He got up, mumbling random nonsense.

Crime and punishment. Dostoevsky. A thought grazed a corner of my mind, startling me: what if Dostoevsky had paired those two words not as synonyms, but as antonyms? Crime and punishment, two utterly irreconcilable things, fire and water. I felt I could almost see into the depths of the scummy, rancid pond, the chaos that was Dostoevsky’s antonym-pairing mind, but no, I couldn’t quite make it out . . . My head spun with thoughts that flickered like a revolving lantern until I heard a shout:

“Hey! You never saw fava beans like these. C’mere!”

Horiki’s voice and expression had changed. Moments ago he had staggered downstairs, and now here he was back again already.

“What is it?” A peculiar excitement filled me.

The two of us descended from the roof to the second floor, and midway to my apartment on the ground floor, Horiki stopped still and whispered “Look!” He pointed.

The small window above my place was open, so I could see inside. The lights were on, illuminating a pair of animals.

My head swam. *It’s all part of being human. All part of being human. Nothing to be surprised about.* Breathing hard, forgetting even to rescue Yoshiko, I stood frozen on the stairs.

Horiki coughed loudly. I tore back upstairs to get away, collapsed on the roof and looked up at the dark summer sky swollen with rain. The emotion that engulfed me then was not anger or disgust or even sorrow, but massive terror. Not the terror of encountering a graveyard ghost, but a wild and overpowering dread with ancient roots, the sort of terror that might arise on glimpsing, among the giant cedars of a Shinto shrine, the figure of a deity

all in white. Beginning that night, my hair turned prematurely gray. I lost all confidence and every vestige of faith in others; I was permanently estranged from all expectation, all joy, all sympathy with the world's affairs. The impact of that night was truly life-shattering. I suffered a frontal blow that cracked my skull between the eyebrows, leaving a wound that still throbs painfully whenever I come near any human being.

"I feel for you, but I hope you learned your lesson. I'm never coming back. This place is a hell on earth." Horiki paused. "Still, you need to forgive Yoshiko. You're no prize yourself. I'm off."

Horiki wasn't stupid enough to hang around in a situation so awkward.

I got up and drank alone, then wept bitter tears, sobbing unrestrainedly. I could have gone on weeping forever.

Before I knew it, Yoshiko was standing behind me with a vacant expression on her face, holding a dish piled high with fava beans. "He said he wouldn't do anything to me but . . ."

"Never mind. Don't say anything. You never knew enough to distrust anybody. Sit down. Let's eat the beans."

We sat side by side and ate the beans. *Is trusting people a sin?* I wondered. The guy was an illiterate shopkeeper, a pipsqueak around thirty. He used to ask me to draw him manga and paid a piddling amount of money for them with great fanfare.

Not surprisingly, he never showed his face again. Somehow my loathing of that shopkeeper paled next to the disgust and rage I felt toward Horiki, who on first stumbling on the scene had done nothing, not so much as coughing loudly before turning back upstairs to tell me. At night, unable to sleep, I groaned in torment.

Forgiving or not forgiving my wife was not an issue. Yoshiko had a genius for trusting people, had never suspected the worst of anyone. And yet, the result was this misery!

God, I ask you: is trusting people a sin?

Rather than Yoshiko's physical defilement, the defilement of her trusting nature was for me a source of such unrelenting suffering that life became

unbearable. To a wretched wimp like me, always trying to gauge people's moods by their expressions, my ability to trust cracked beyond repair, Yoshiko's innocent faith in others had been as refreshing as a leafy waterfall. Overnight, the pure water of that cascade had changed to yellow sludge. From that time on, she trembled at my every smile and frown.

She would start when I called her and look anywhere but at me. No matter how I joked around, trying to make her laugh, she was nervous and tense, and she took to addressing me with honorifics all the time.

Could an innocent, trusting heart be the wellspring of all crime, all sin?

I sought out and read books involving the rape of a wife. None of the women in the books had been violated in as wretched a way as Yoshiko, it seemed to me. What happened to her wasn't suited for a novel anyway. If there'd been a smidgeon of romance between her and the pipsqueak shopkeeper, I might even have found it easier to bear; all that happened was that one summer night she trusted him, and just like that, precisely because she'd been trustful, a frontal blow split my head open between the eyes, my voice turned hoarse, my hair went prematurely gray, and Yoshiko was doomed to be a bundle of nerves for the rest of her life.

Most of the novels I read attached great weight to whether or not the husband forgave his wife's "act," but that didn't strike me as a very big or pressing issue. Happy is the husband who retains the right to forgive or not to forgive. A man unable to bring himself to forgive his wife ought to swiftly divorce her and take a new wife; if he can't do that, he should forgive her and display tolerance. In either case the situation is resolved, whichever way the husband's feelings incline. To summarize, while an incident of that nature surely comes as a great shock to the husband, it is just that, a shock, and not an endless series of lashing waves. This was the sort of trouble that the anger of an authoritative husband could cure. But in our case, the husband, me, was totally lacking in authority.

Upon reflection, I came to feel that everything was completely my fault, so that far from getting angry, I was unable to utter a word of reproach. The wife, moreover, had been violated because of the rare virtue she possessed,

one that the husband had long admired: the unbearably sweet virtue of an innocent, trusting soul.

Is innocent trust a sin?

Having called into question the one virtue I had relied on, I lost my moorings and turned to drink. My expression became extremely mean, I drank cheap spirits all day, my teeth fell out, and the manga I drew were all but pornographic. Let me be perfectly clear: around then I began making copies of erotic prints to sell illegally. I wanted money to buy alcohol. I would look at Yoshiko, who always nervously looked away, and I'd reason that since she didn't know enough to be on her guard, maybe she'd been with the shopkeeper more than once. What about Horiki? Had she been with him, too? And with other men I didn't know? My doubts multiplied, but I lacked the courage to ask her outright and get a straight answer. Writhing in my usual anxiety and fear, I drank. When I was drunk, I would ask her a leading question or two, my heart oscillating foolishly between joy and sorrow, while on the surface I continued to play the clown. Then, after inflicting loathsome, hellish caresses on her, I would fall fast asleep.

Late one December night, I came home in a drunken stupor and felt like drinking sugar water. Yoshiko was sleeping, so I went into the kitchen and looked around for the sugar bowl. When I lifted the lid, instead of sugar I found a small, narrow black box. I picked it up casually and was aghast at the writing on the label. Half of it had been scratched off, but the name in Western lettering was clearly legible: DIAL.

At the time I drank cheap spirits exclusively and wasn't using sleeping pills. But as a chronic insomniac, I was familiar with most brands and knew that this boxful constituted more than a lethal dose. The seal was unbroken. She must have hidden the pills here with the intent to do herself in sometime, even going so far as to scratch off the brand name. Yoshiko, poor kid, was unable to read Western letters, so she must have thought it was enough if she scratched off only the name in Japanese. (You did nothing wrong, my dear.)

Quietly, taking care not to make a sound, I filled a cup with water, then

slowly and deliberately broke the seal, poured the entire contents into my mouth, and calmly drained the cup. Then I turned off the light and went to bed.

For three whole days, I slept the sleep of the dead. The doctor judged that it was an accidental overdose and kindly refrained from notifying the police. When I began to come out of it, the first words out of my mouth were reportedly “I’m going home.” What I may have meant by “home,” I have no idea, but at any rate I apparently said those words and cried bitterly.

Gradually the mist cleared, and there by my pillow sat Flatfish, looking extremely grim.

“The last time, too, it was late December, the time of year when we’re all crazily busy. By always picking the end of the year for his shenanigans, he makes *my* life unbearable.”

He was addressing this complaint to the madam of the bar in Kyobashi. I called out to her:

“Madam.”

“Yes, what is it? Have you woken up?” She smiled, bringing her face close to mine.

Tears poured down my cheeks. “Help me leave Yoshiko.” The words surprised even me.

She sat up and breathed a sigh.

Then I made a slip of the tongue so comical, so absurd, I hardly know how to describe it: “I’m going where there are no women.”

Flatfish guffawed, Madam giggled, and I, still shedding tears, turned red and gave a nervous laugh.

“Yep,” said Flatfish, laughing foolishly on and on, “that’s what you should do all right. Go someplace with no women. With women around, you’re finished. A place with no women: now there’s a good idea!”

A place with no women. Right. Yet my absurd, incoherent ravings were to be fulfilled later on in the direst way.

Yoshiko seemed to have the idea that I had taken the overdose in atonement for her sin. Now she was even more timid around me than

before. She never smiled, no matter what I said, and hardly spoke a word. I found being in the apartment with her so oppressive that I took to going out like the old days and drinking cheap liquor. But ever since swallowing the pills, I had grown thin and gaunt. My arms and legs felt heavy, and I'd begun to neglect my work. Flatfish had left me some money. ("A little something from Shibuta," he wrote on the envelope, making it seem as if the money came from him, but I sensed that once again it was from my brothers back home. Unlike the time I ran away from Flatfish's house, now I was able to see dimly through his self-important posturing. With equal guile, I pretended to be unaware of what was going on and thanked him meekly, not at all sure why he and they played that convoluted game. The situation made me extremely uncomfortable.)

I used the money to take a solo trip to the hot springs in southern Izu peninsula. A leisurely tour of hot springs was not my style, however. At the thought of Yoshiko, I was utterly forlorn, in no mood to sit and gaze tranquilly from my hotel room at the mountain scenery. Without bothering to change into the dressing gown the inn provided, let alone soak in the hot waters, I would rush out and take refuge in dingy bars where I drowned myself in liquor. I returned to Tokyo in worse shape than ever.

On my first night back in Tokyo, there was a heavy snowfall. I wandered drunkenly through the Ginza backstreets, singing a line from a war song under my breath over and over again: *Here am I, hundreds of leagues from home*. I walked along kicking the snow piling up on the ground, and then suddenly I vomited. For the first time I brought up blood, forming a big Rising Sun flag on the snow. I crouched down for a while and then with both hands scooped up clean snow and used it to wash my face, weeping.

Where does this path lead? In the distance a little girl was singing a nursery song, her voice so faint that I wondered if I was imagining it. Misery. In this world there were so many unhappy people—perhaps it was fair to say there were only unhappy people. But other unhappy people can boldly protest their lot, and society can easily understand and offer sympathy. My unhappiness, however, was entirely the result of my own

errors, leaving me no way to protest my lot to anyone. If I did stammer out a single word, not only Flatfish but everybody was sure to react with horror and retort, “How dare you talk that way!” Whether I was selfish or simply faint-hearted I had no idea, but either way, I was sinful to the core and naturally plunged deeper and deeper into the abyss of sorrow. I had no concrete measure to halt my descent.

I got up and, having decided to seek some kind of medicine or other for the moment, went into a nearby pharmacy. The woman behind the counter looked at me and froze, with her eyes opened wide and her head lifted, as if caught in the flash of a camera. There was neither surprise nor aversion in her eyes; the look she gave me was pleading, almost yearning. *Ah, she is unhappy, too,* I thought. Unhappy people are sensitive to the unhappiness of others. Then I realized she was standing with difficulty, on crutches. I suppressed the impulse to rush to her side. We went on looking at each other until I felt the sting of tears, and then I saw tears stream from her big eyes.

Without a word, I turned and left the pharmacy, staggered home, and drank a salt solution that Yoshiko prepared for me. Silently I went to bed and stayed there all the next day on the pretext that I felt a cold coming on. At night, bothered by the secret knowledge that I had vomited blood, I got up and went back to the pharmacy. This time, forcing a smile, I confessed the state I was in and asked the woman’s advice.

“You have to quit drinking.”

We were like blood relatives.

“I may be an alcoholic. I’d like a drink right now.”

“No, you mustn’t. My husband had TB. He used to say he’d kill the germs with liquor, and drank himself silly. Shortened his life.”

“I’m so restless, I can’t do anything. I’m terrified, a total mess.”

“I’ll give you some medicine. But you’ve got to quit drinking.”

She was a widow with an only son. The boy had entered medical school in Chiba Prefecture or somewhere only to come down with the same illness as his father and land in the hospital. She lived with her father-in-law, a

bedridden paralytic. The woman herself had been stricken with polio at the age of five and had a bad leg. She bustled around the shop on her crutches, selecting a variety of medicines from a drawer here and a shelf there and laying them out for me.

This is to build your blood.

This is a vitamin solution and syringe.

These are calcium pills. This is diastase to prevent an upset stomach or diarrhea.

Tenderly, she explained each of the half-dozen medicines, but the tenderness of that unhappy woman was too much for me. Finally she said, “This is for when you want a drink so much you can’t stand it,” and swiftly handed me a small box wrapped in paper.

It was morphine.

She told me it was less harmful than alcohol, and since I was starting to see the sordid side of a drunkard’s life, the prospect of escaping the bottle’s satanic clutches filled me with elation. Without a bit of hesitation, I gave myself an injection in the arm. Just like that, my anxiety, fretfulness and discomfort vanished, and I became inordinately cheerful and voluble. After an injection, my debilities forgotten, I would devote myself to my manga drawing with renewed vigor. I developed the peculiar habit of bursting into laughter while drawing.

One vial per day soon turned into two; around the time I hit four, I could no longer work without the drug.

“You can’t go on like this. Once you’re addicted, you’re really in for it.”

At this warning from the woman at the pharmacy, I felt as if I were already a serious addict. (I am highly susceptible to suggestion. Told “Don’t spend this money—though if I know you, you won’t listen,” I have the strange illusion that not to spend it would be wrong, going against expectations. Inevitably, I spend the money immediately.) Nervousness over becoming an addict only led me to use the drug more and more.

“Please! I’m asking you. One more box. I promise I’ll settle my bill at the end of the month.”

“You can settle up anytime you want as far as I’m concerned. But watch out for the police, they like to crack down.”

A dark and murky aura always surrounded me, giving me the shady air of an outcast.

“Can’t you say something to put them off? Please! I’ll give you a kiss.”

She turned red.

I pressed harder. “Without the drug, my work goes nowhere. For me, it works like a tonic.”

“In that case, you’d be better off with hormone injections.”

“Don’t be ridiculous. I need alcohol, or that drug. Unless I have one or the other, I can’t get any work done.”

“Alcohol is no good.”

“Right? Ever since I started using that drug, I haven’t had a drop. I feel like a new man. I don’t intend to go on being a lousy manga artist forever, you know. I’m quitting the bottle. I’ll recover my health, study and become a great painter. Just wait and see. This is a crucial turning point for me. So please, please do me this favor. Shall I give you a kiss?”

She started to laugh. “What am I going to do with you! Don’t blame me if you wind up addicted.” Her crutches clicked on the floor as she fetched the drug from a shelf. “I can’t give you the whole box. I know you’d use it up right away. Here’s half.”

“Stingy, aren’t we? Oh well, I suppose I’ll just have to get by.”

I went home and immediately gave myself an injection.

“Doesn’t it hurt?” Yoshiko asked timidly.

“Sure it does. But I have to do it whether I want to or not, in order to work more efficiently. I’m on top of things these days, as I’m sure you’ve noticed, right? Now, it’s back to work! Time to buckle down!” I burbled frenetically.

Once I even pounded on the pharmacy door late in the evening. When the widow hobbled to the door in her nightgown, her crutches clicking, I threw my arms around her and kissed her, pretending to weep.

Silently she handed me an entire box.

By the time I realized beyond all doubt that the drug was as sordid and disgusting as cheap liquor—no, more so—I was a complete addict. I knew no shame whatsoever. To afford the drug, I again started churning out copies of erotic woodblock prints and even entered into an illicit affair with the crippled widow.

I want to die. I'd be better off dead. There's no way out now. No matter what I do, I fall apart every single time and pile shame on shame. Who am I to dream of a leafy waterfall? I'll just go on committing one sickening, despicable sin after another. My suffering will only expand and intensify. I want to die. I have to die. Living is the source of sin.

Even as I brooded on these things, I raced back and forth between the apartment and the pharmacy in a frenzy.

However much more work I did, as my use of the drug increased at the same rate, I soon owed a horrific amount of money. The sight of me brought tears to the widow's eyes. I wept, too.

It was a living hell.

To escape this living hell, as a last resort—knowing that failure would leave me with no option but to hang myself—I decided on a step tantamount to betting on the existence of God: I wrote a long letter to my father back home and told him all about my predicament (though I couldn't bring myself to write about the widow).

The result was only to make a bad situation worse. I waited on tenterhooks but no answer came, and frustration and anxiety drove me to increase still more the amount of the injections.

One day, I quietly made up my mind that I would give myself ten doses that night and jump into the river. That very afternoon, Flatfish showed up with Horiki in tow, as if he'd seen through my plan with diabolical clairvoyance.

"I hear you coughed blood."

Horiki sat cross-legged in front of me and said this with the gentlest smile I had ever seen. Overcome with gratitude and joy, I bent my head and wept. That one gentle smile of his was all it took to completely destroy and

annihilate me.

They bundled me into a car. “For starters, you need to be in the hospital. Leave the rest to us.” Flatfish urged this in a soft, heartfelt tone—a tone of such utter tranquility that I am tempted to call it “merciful”—and, like someone utterly lacking in will or judgment, able only to sob, I quietly did as he and Horiki said. We three and Yoshiko rode in the car for quite some time, jostling and swaying. Just as it was growing dark, the car pulled up in front of a big hospital in the middle of a forest.

A sanatorium, I had no doubt.

A young, suspiciously mild-mannered doctor examined me carefully and then said with what I can only call a shy smile, “Well, you’ll need to stay here a while and rest.”

Flatfish, Horiki and Yoshiko were all to go home and leave me there on my own. Yoshiko handed me a cloth bundle containing a change of clothes, then silently drew from her obi sash the hypodermic needle and what remained of the drug. After all this time, she still thought it was a tonic.

“No, I don’t need it anymore.”

This was truly remarkable: for the first time in my life, I had turned down something I’d been offered. My unhappiness was the unhappiness of someone who lacked the power to say no. I had long been cowed by the fear that rejecting an offer would cause both my heart and that of the other person to crack beyond repair. But now, offered the morphine I’d been seeking in such a frenzy, I had declined it in a perfectly natural way. Perhaps Yoshiko’s angelic innocence had moved me. Perhaps in that moment I had already ceased to be an addict.

However, the young doctor with the shy smile immediately led me off to a ward and locked the door with a clang. It was a psychiatric ward.

I’m going where there are no women: that foolish cry, uttered in delirium after I took the sleeping pills, had come true in an uncanny way. The ward held only male lunatics, and the nurses, too, were all men. There wasn’t a single woman.

I was no longer a criminal but a lunatic. No, I definitely wasn’t insane.

Not for one moment had I lost my mind. But then that's what madmen generally say. So apparently, anyone committed to this ward was out of his mind, and anyone not committed here was normal.

God, I ask you: is non-resistance a sin?

Rendered tearful by Horiki's strangely beatific smile, powerless to exercise judgment or make any protest, I had gotten into the car and been taken here, and so I had become a lunatic. Now even if I got out of this place, the label would be branded on my forehead: *lunatic*. Or perhaps *total wreck*.

No longer human.

I had totally ceased to be a human being.

I arrived in early summer, when from my iron-barred window I could see red water lilies in the hospital's little pond. Three months passed, and as cosmos flowers began to bloom in the garden, unexpectedly my brother came to get me, accompanied by Flatfish. He told me that Father had died the previous month of a stomach ulcer.

"The family is prepared to say no more about your past or cause you any more worry about how you are to live. You won't have to do anything. In return, we ask only this: although you're no doubt attached to Tokyo in many ways, we want you to leave the city and go recuperate in the country."

Flatfish had gone around making amends for all I'd done in Tokyo, so I could rest easy on that score, my brother concluded in his usual sober, tense manner of speaking.

The mountains and rivers of home seemed to rise before my eyes, and I nodded faintly.

A total wreck, that's what I was.

Learning that my father was dead left me stunned. He was gone. That familiar, terrifying presence that had never left my heart for a moment was no more. I felt as if the vessel of my suffering were now empty. More than likely, it was because of my father that the vessel had become so heavy. I lost all motivation. I lost even the capacity to suffer.

My brother did exactly as promised. He bought me a small thatch-roof house on the edge of a hot spring resort on the coast, four or five hours south by train from the town where I was born and raised. The climate here is unusually warm for the Tohoku region. Though the house has five rooms, it's quite old, with peeling walls and worm-eaten pillars, seemingly beyond repair. My brother also hired a woman to look after me, an ugly crone twice my age with dreadful faded hair.

A little more than three years has gone by. In that time, Tetsu, the old woman, has violated me several times in a bizarre way. Now and then we quarrel like a married couple. My chest ailment is sometimes better and sometimes worse, and my weight fluctuates up and down. Sometimes I cough blood. Yesterday I sent Tetsu to the pharmacy to buy the sedative Calmotine. She came back with a box of a different shape from the usual one, but I didn't think anything of it. I took ten pills before bed but never got the least bit sleepy, which seemed odd. Then my stomach cramped and I went to the toilet, where I had an explosive bout of diarrhea. I went three more times after that. Suspicious, I checked the box and found I'd taken Henomotine, a laxative.

I lay face up on my futon with a hot-water bottle on my stomach and started to scold Tetsu—"Hey, these aren't sleeping pills, they're laxatives!"—but got the giggles and couldn't finish. "Total wreck" must be a comic noun. I took laxatives to go to sleep.

Now I am neither happy nor unhappy.

Everything passes.

This is the one truth I have gleaned from human society, where I have lived as in a hell of screaming agony.

Everything passes.

This year I'll be twenty-seven. My hair has turned so gray that people generally think I'm over forty.

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Epilogue

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あとがき

I never knew the madman who wrote these notebooks. I did, however, have a passing acquaintance with the woman who (as near as I can tell) figures in them as the madam of a bar in Kyobashi. She was small with a pale complexion, narrow eyes that tilted upward, a high nose bridge and an air of such firmness that she looked less like a beautiful woman than a handsome young man. The events in the notebooks seem to have taken place in Tokyo around 1930. A friend and I went to the bar in question a time or two for highballs, but that wasn't until 1935 or so, about the time Japan's army started going openly on the rampage. I never had the chance to cross paths with the man who wrote the notebooks.

However, this past February I called on an old friend who'd relocated to Funabashi City in Chiba Prefecture, someone I knew from college days who'd gone on to become a lecturer at the local women's college. I had in fact asked him to find a marriage partner for a relative of mine. While near the coast, I intended to pick up fresh seafood for my family, and set off carrying a rucksack.

Funabashi is a fairly big city overlooking a muddy sea. My friend had moved there only recently, and I had trouble finding his place even after telling local people the address and asking for directions. It was cold out, and my shoulders ached from the weight of the rucksack. Drawn by the sound of a violin recording, I pushed open the door of a coffee shop and went in.

The owner looked familiar. Sure enough, she turned out to be none other than the manager of that little bar in Kyobashi a decade ago. She remembered me right away, and after reacting to the unexpected reunion with exaggerated surprise and laughter, we immediately exchanged tales of being burned out of house and home in the fire bombings, almost boasting, the way everyone did.

We also exchanged the usual pleasantries of people who meet after some time:

“You haven’t changed a bit.”

“No, I’m an old lady now. Falling apart. You’re the one who looks young.”

“Not at all. I’ve got three kids. I’m here stocking up on food for them.”

Then we turned to news about the doings of mutual friends. After a while she asked in a different tone, “Did you by any chance know Yo-chan?”

When I said I did not, she disappeared into the back of the shop and returned with three notebooks and three photographs which she handed to me.

“Maybe you could find material for a novel here,” she said.

As I am incapable of writing anything based on material that’s been thrust upon me, I toyed with the idea of handing everything back on the spot, but the photos (I wrote in the prologue to this book about the three photographs and their weirdness) were so fascinating that I agreed to keep the notebooks for a time. Promising to stop by again on my way home, I asked if she knew so-and-so at such-and-such an address, a teacher at the women’s college. It turned out that she did. They were both newcomers to the neighborhood. He sometimes came by the coffee shop, she said, and lived right around the

corner.

That evening, I had a few drinks with my friend, and he put me up for the night. I stayed awake all night, absorbed in the notebooks. The events recorded there had taken place some time ago, but I felt sure the contents would appeal to readers today. Rather than make any clumsy additions, I decided that asking a magazine publisher to run them just as they were would be far more meaningful.

I picked up some dried fish for the kids, left my friend's place, and stopped by the coffee shop again.

"Thanks for yesterday. And by the way," I said, getting right down to it, "do you mind if I hang onto the notebooks for a while?"

"Please do."

"Is this person still alive?"

"I have no idea. About ten years ago, a package containing the notebooks and the photos arrived at my place in Kyobashi. The sender had to be Yo-chan, but there was no return name or address. The notebooks got mixed in with some other things and somehow survived the bombing. I read them for the first time just the other day, and . . ."

"Did you cry?"

"No, not cry so much as . . . It's awful for someone to end up that way, isn't it? Just awful."

"Ten years ago, was it? Then he could be dead by now. He must have sent the package to you in gratitude. Some of what he wrote sounds exaggerated, but you seem to have come in for considerable suffering. If everything he wrote is true, and I were his friend, I might have wanted to pack him off to a mental hospital myself."

"His father was to blame." She sounded nonchalant. "The Yo-chan we knew was sweet and thoughtful. If he just hadn't been a drinker . . . but no, even then, he was a dear boy. An angel."

THE END

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Asia Pacific
Berkeley Books Pte Ltd
3 Kallang Sector #04-01
Singapore 349278
Tel: (65) 6741-2178
Fax: (65) 6741-2179
inquiries@periplus.com.sg
www.tuttlepublishing.com

Japan
Tuttle Publishing
Yaekari Building, 3rd Floor
5-4-12 Osaki Shinagawa-ku
Tokyo 141 0032 Japan
Tel: 81 (3) 5437 0171
Fax: 81 (3) 5437 0755
sales@tuttle.co.jp
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"Dazai's brand of egoistic pessimism dovetails organically with the emo chic of this cultural moment."

—The New York Times

A completely new translation of Osamu Dazai's great masterpiece by award-winning translator Juliet Winters Carpenter.

No Longer Human is the story of Yozo Oba, who finds it impossible to form meaningful relationships with family or friends. As a child he copes by acting the fool—mocking himself while entertaining others; as an adult he turns to alcohol, sex and drugs. Written in 1948 and based closely on Dazai's own life, the timeless and universal themes of social alienation, failure and one man's inner torture at his inability to feel like a normal human have made this one of the most widely read novels in Japan.

This contemporary translation will be welcomed by all fans of modern Japanese literature as well as by readers familiar with Osamu Dazai from the wildly popular manga and anime series *Bungo Stray Dogs*, where he is the lead character.

Osamu Dazai (1909–1948) was the pen name of Shuji Tsushima, the tenth of eleven children born to a wealthy landowner and politician. Dazai studied French literature at the University of Tokyo, but never received a degree. In 1933 magazines first began to publish his work. He made five suicide attempts, a subject he deals with in much of his work. Despite his troubled life and rebellious spirit, Dazai wrote in simple and colloquial style, conveying his personal torments through literature. His life ended in a double suicide with a married lover.

Juliet Winters Carpenter is professor emeritus at Doshisha Women's College of Liberal Arts in Kyoto and has received numerous awards for her translation work including the 2021–2022 Lindsey and Masao Miyoshi Translation Prize for a lifetime of achievement as a translator of modern Japanese literature.

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